

# DROPZONE

COMMANDER

## RECONQUEST PRIMER 1



TTCOMBAT



# THE CRADLE WORLDS - STOLEN JEWELS

## A TALE OF RESISTANCE

As United Colonial boots made planetfall on their long lost homelands, they began to see firsthand what had become of the glittering cities of legend spoke of by historians. Decaying ruins, majestic even in their plight, contrasted with well maintained districts, occupied and twisted by their new overlords, the dreaded Scourge. The vile aliens were not the only denizens on the Cradle Worlds however. Contact was quickly established with many disparate Resistance bands, some of which had been actively taking the fight to the enemy despite being hopelessly outnumbered. To understand the nature of these Resistance groups, it's vital to look back at the development and subjugation of the Cradle Worlds in times before the UCM's Reconquest. Doubtless, in the 163 years between the Scourge invasion and the arrival of the UCM, tales of heroism, loss and suffering are legion.

However, the events which would transpire on Eden Prime were mirrored on many other Cradle Worlds, so can be treated as a case study. Where there is variance of special interest to strategists it will be addressed later. For now, the story of Eden Prime's darkest years will serve as a paradigm of human endurance in the face of terrible adversity...

## A SECOND EARTH REVEALED

The Eden System holds a special place in the collective heart of humanity, as Eden Prime was the very first Cradle World presented to mankind by the outwardly benevolent Shaltari, in the year 2347. Early space exploration was more or less random due to the limitations of human foldspace technology, and while several habitable worlds had been explored, Eden Prime was the first that could truly be described as 'Earth-like'.

Its beauty intoxicated the senses of early explorers, more than the most fanciful tales of pre-industrial Earth ever could. It was an utterly unspoilt paradise of lush jungles, aquamarine oceans and measureless mineral wealth.

In the early days of Human-Shaltari alliance, millions of settlers chose to make the voyage to Eden rather than continue to live in the vastly overpopulated metropolises of Earth.

Thanks to fusion generators and vast manpower, Eden Prime was quickly exploited to the full. Cities sprouted from the plains at an astonishing rate as vast earthworks delved into Eden's rich crust.

As the first Cradle World settled by humanity, Eden naturally became the most populous and developed. As the Human-Shaltari alliance flourished, other such planets would be revealed, although none would eclipse Eden in urban grandeur or industrial scope.

Within 30 years, the alliance abruptly broke down as it became known that the deceitful aliens were planning to use humans as foot soldiers in wars with other Shaltari Tribes, exploiting mankind's numerical superiority. Plainly, such a war against a far more advanced foe would have been bloody in the extreme, the human leadership quickly broke off the alliance in disgust. Why the Shaltari appeared to have misjudged the mood of their allies so spectacularly is still a mystery. The aliens seemed astonishingly in tune with human speech, gestures and culture when they needed to be; making this diplomatic miss-step unfathomable to modern UCM theoreticians.

Whatever the reason, mankind was left to remain on Eden Prime and continued to prosper with little comment from the Shaltari who casually departed the planet. High military alert was maintained for some time after, although the feared Shaltari vengeance never materialised.

Mankind continued to populate and develop the Eden System for the next 130 years. Eden II, IV and VII would all sport human settlements by the year 2507, the year that all this shining progress would be abruptly and brutally shattered.





## DEATH IN PARADISE

A titanic Scourge invasion fleet hit the Eden System with the same sledgehammer force that had brought Earth to its knees. Thousands of disturbingly outlandish invasion craft blackened the skies and rained white hot plasma down on Eden's hopelessly unprepared defenders.

A significant proportion of Eden's defence force and most of her ships had been lost to the bitter infighting between the Abandonist and the Loyalist factions prior to the invasion. Warnings of an impending apocalypse delivered by a mysterious AI entity known as the White Sphere had been broadcast on every Cradle World in perfect harmony; a message which would result in perfect chaos. Those who would leave and those who would stay vied and killed for possession of military assets, ships and food to such an extent that the remaining population was critically weakened when the Scourge made planetfall exactly one year later.

fleeing Earth for Eden, only to discover the same nightmare waiting for them. Within a matter of hours, the disorganised remnants of Eden's defenders were quickly swept aside and the horror of Scourge occupation began to envelop the Eden System like a noxious cloud.

The vast majority of the System's population failed to escape the encroaching tendrils of Scourge forces, both planetside and in space. Those who did manage to break through the naval blockade fled to the far less amenable frontier colonies that mankind had discovered independently. These planets were miraculously unmolested by Scourge attack and their foldspace nodes were quickly reconfigured to prevent pursuit. While this proved effective in concealing these colonies from the aggressor (who also seemed to need nodes for accurate jumps), it condemned the remaining inhabitants of Eden and the other Cradle Worlds to bleak isolation. While the refugees and inhabitants of the colonies would eventually rise from the ashes and return as the UCM, the intervening years on Eden Prime were dark, savage and unbearably hopeless.

## A CLASH OF LIGHT AND DARK

While military defeat was decisive and almost total, a flicker of human defiance remained, kept aflame by the desire to live at any cost. Most who survived the initial onslaught did so by fleeing underground or away from the urban centres where the Scourge forces had concentrated.

Eden Prime in particular had a vast pre-war population and a heavily exploited surface. Thousands of miles of underground service tunnels, myriad factory caverns and hidden military installations were almost as common as the glittering Neo-Deco skyscrapers on the surface. The planners of Eden's urbanisation had been determined not to deface the planet's beautiful surface with merely functional architecture (as their predecessors had done on Earth), so they hid such structures underground. These subterranean regions became a lifeline for many, from the fabulously wealthy socialites of the centres to the workers of the caverns who were intimately familiar with such places.

This may seem like a microcosm for what was happening on the colonies at around the same time, where decadent and privileged refugees fled to the frontier worlds. However, on Eden, things were different. Most inhabitants of the colonies were pioneering, accepting, adventurous types who had left the Cradle Worlds in search of fame and glory and were, crucially, few in number. They had to adapt to a new situation with millions of arriving refugees at their door and did so exceptionally well.

When the inhabitants of the surface of Eden Prime fled to their planet's underworld, they came face-to-face with the darker realm that had propped up their palaces of light. A burning resentment had been seething for decades between a forgotten underclass and the privileged of the surface. Many had led lives of affected aestheticism and pleasure, unconcerned or even ignorant of the work of the millions that kept Eden's cities running. It's safe to say that in those initial frantic hours, many personal scores were settled with both masters and affluent strangers in flight to the dark. Scourge weapons were far from being the only cause of merciless death.

What emerged from this clash of two classes varied wildly between regions, cities and sectors. Several descended into total anarchy while others managed to maintain a semblance of order. Sometimes, the presence of a strong and pragmatic leader would be enough to stem the bloodshed while at other times radicals took the chance to avenge themselves on their former 'betters'.

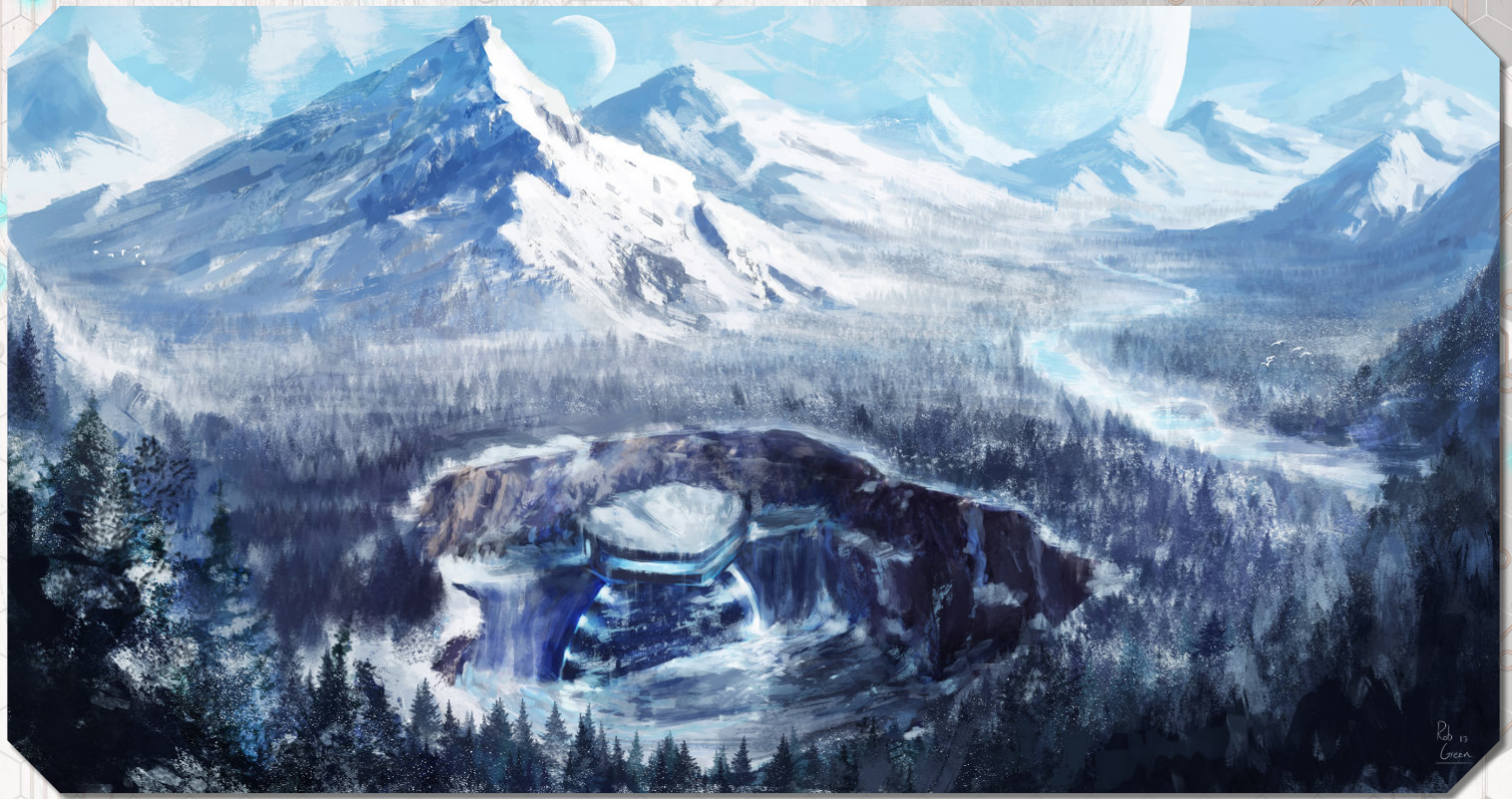
As the first few weeks passed, a ragtag collection of survivor groups began to form. Initially, contact between regions was frequent. Much of the underground infrastructure remained intact and communications and travel were often possible. Materiel, supplies and many people were relocated to strongpoints or hides during this crucial period. However, within months of the Scourge consolidating their iron grip on the surface cities, they began to inexorably advance into the central subterranean regions like a creeping miasma.

## THE ASHES SWAMPED

Those who considered their position unassailable were not to last long. After a few questing reconnaissance tendrils of Scourge forces explored the most prominent areas of human defiance, the full weight of Scourge power descended to the depths. Their tactics were different this time - with (in their eyes) the planet already won, the Scourge advanced slowly, but methodically, carefully isolating the largest pockets and abducting as many survivors alive as possible. They had nowhere to run, and the Scourge knew it. It was more or less at this point that the survivors realised to their horror that the Scourge warriors in the newest equipment were once human - living shells of their former compatriots taken as hosts for the foul alien neuroparasites. Every comrade captured would be another slave to the will of the Scourge race, and another enemy to kill.

The largest free redoubts were quickly swept away, leaving only scattered and tattered remnants of a force which knew itself to be divided even before the assault began. Seemingly satisfied with their work, the Scourge withdrew to the surface to begin their reign as masters of Eden.





## THE WILDERNESS YEARS

Once the most significant pockets of survivors were assimilated, it became apparent that the Scourge had little stomach to exterminate or assimilate every last human being left in the tunnels. The survivors reasoned that the Scourge were like a predatory beast after feasting on a kill - slated by their gluttony, they were content to wallow in their victory while lesser, insignificant creatures scuttled round their clawed feet. The few humans left alive and free seemed to be no more than a minor nuisance to the Scourge - like mice in a cowshed. While beneath the Scourge's notice, the remnants of Eden's population finally began to unite in adversity even where conflict had festered.

As time in the dark gloom stretched from days into months and then months into years, the Resistance (as they commonly called themselves now) began to form smaller and more independent groups. Now that Scourge eyes were elsewhere, they quietly relocated to the most secretive, secluded and forsaken places on Eden Prime, demolishing passages to the surface as they went. The survivors would have to learn how to live a new and harsh life, and they would need to adapt constantly.

As time wore on, a kind of natural selection and forced societal development took place. Only the most disciplined, united, ruthless or savage of bands remained intact. Some were held together by leaders who inspired fear, respect or admiration, and a few by unshakable solidarity. As weaker groups came into contact with larger ones they either joined willingly, were forced into obedience or were slaughtered for their valuables. Whenever large bands met, they normally went their separate ways at first, keen not to signal their presence in numbers great enough for the Scourge to show interest in attacking again. Apart from these infrequent encounters there was almost no contact between Resistance bands as most communications channels had now been repurposed by the Scourge for their own ends. It was also deemed far too reckless to use any form of long range wireless comms for fear of interception.

What was most unexpected was the rarity of Scourge forays into the subterranean regions. Many theories were advanced for this, although the most common was that it had something to do with communications. The Scourge did not seem to want to stray too far from their largest constructs on the surface or from their greatest concentrations of troops. It was clear that this was less about distance than the sheer amount of rock between them and the surface. With Scourge comms still a mystery to the Resistance, theories about some form of collective Scourge 'gestalt' consciousness grew, as they seemed able to communicate without speech.

Perhaps the leadership caste (whatever they were) preferred for their minions not to stray too far beyond their control. Whatever the reason, Resistance groups in the deepest areas were left largely undisturbed by their tormentors. Supplies were relatively plentiful for the first 80 years or so. The vast quantities of provisions placed in hides before the Scourge attacks were mostly intact and sustained many communities over the long and dark years. In time, the attack faded from living memory - all that remained were stories and relics of a bygone era.

However, to say that most of the Resistance regressed to a primitive state would be incorrect. While gloomy, cold and unattractive, the subterranean regions of Eden Prime housed most of the manufacturing sectors and military bases on the planet. Occasionally, stockpiles of surplus, mothballed, reserve or undelivered military vehicles were in place and even used on occasion. However, most bands were fearful of running anything too powerful, lest they attract attention from above. As the centenary of occupation approached, the Resistance had done little so far to deserve the name, save the fact of their continued existence. Very few left alive had witnessed the attack in person and an unhappy restlessness began seep into the hearts of the populations. By now, many bands had expanded into small societies; some were large enough by now to be called civilisations.



Most had never seen the sun in their lives and had not encountered a single Scourge construct or warrior. A desire to do something, to expand, to progress and be counted as human beings was taking hold of these fledgling societies. As the mental hunger for progress grew, a real physical hunger loomed. Supplies were running out and something had to be done before each and every society tore itself apart in the anarchy of primal desperation.

## THE RESISTANCE RISES

After so many years in quiet isolation, many Resistance leaders become bolder as the need for action overcame fear. Visits to the surface were more commonplace and often had real tactical focus, with clear objectives to achieve. Many Resistance societies carefully relocated to remote surface locations during this period. The need to grow food and live in the fresh air outweighed the risks - clearly, there was no future in forever skulking in the shadows. Swamps, dense forests and isolated outposts became popular surface bases although most bands did not wholly abandon the tunnels, which were treated as vital bolt holes should the Scourge attack.

The Resistance soon learned that Scourge infantry preferred to move in subdued light or in darkness. Full sunlight appeared to be unpleasant for Scourge hosts, whose tendency to sweat profusely grew much worse in the heat of the day. The nature of Scourge warriors had also begun to change. The 'Lizzard warriors' common during the early years had almost totally died off, to be replaced with mostly human hosts. These were apparently the same individuals that were taken over 100 years previously and they appeared not to have aged, although they were seemed a little less in control of themselves than in the past. Their movements were less coordinated and their thirst seemed to be getting more extreme. The change was subtle at this point, but noticeable. It certainly made Scourge patrols during daylight less frequent, especially during Eden Prime's long summers.

As the second century of occupation ground past, this trend would continue, giving the Resistance a chance to develop, expand and gain a foothold on the surface. Use of vehicles began to increase during these years as they learned how to avoid and predict Scourge movements. Any functional ex-military units were carefully husbanded by the leadership due to their scarcity. Nevertheless, they were lovingly maintained, frequently repaired and kept in working order for the dire days on which they were needed. The conversion of civilian vehicles to combat roles became increasingly common. These were plentiful in the decaying zones of surface cities that Scourge forces had abandoned or considered surplus. As they were few in number, the Resistance had plentiful supplies of weapons since the underground stockpiles were designed for real armies of far larger size.

By the early 2650's the scent of change was in the air. With their oppressors now in a clear state of slow decay, the time was deemed right for the Resistance to finally start to live up to their name and take the fight back to the hated enemy. Although the Scourge were clearly in a form of decline, they were still massively superior in technology, weaponry and above all in numbers. All the Resistance could hope to do was harass their enemy in small but significant ways. It felt hugely liberating for those that chose to go on the offensive after a lifetime of lurking in the shadows and forgotten places, no better than rats in the face of lions.

There were several groups however that did not share this view. Some of the more ruthless and totalitarian societies that had emerged from the tunnels were often less than keen to fight a vastly superior enemy and were more concerned with expanding their own power bases. Several power crazed warlords, Machiavellian schemers and egotistical dictators had emerged, each focused on increasing the scope of their own power, normally to the detriment of other Resistance societies. These 'Ferals' as they came to be known (although this is something of a blanket term and doesn't always best describe them) played only a small part in fighting the Scourge unless something worth capturing presented itself.





Those fighting Guerrilla style for some sort of human progress had a difficult war from the outset. However brave, foolhardy or skilful they were, they knew they had almost no hope of making a meaningful impact against the enemy's military. In the early years above ground they confined themselves to raiding supply depots, sabotage, recon and other partisan activities.

## RECON REVELATIONS

Reconnaissance missions yielded some interesting and sometimes horrific discoveries. Breeding camps designed to mass produce vat-grown humans for Scourge parasite implantation were discovered. With a shortage of new hosts, the Scourge were clearly trying to replenish their numbers as the earlier parasites were reaching the ends of their lives. Fortunately, human biology seemed to be less than perfect for this process, judging by the mountains of naked, deformed corpses dumped and burned outside such facilities on a daily basis. While they could replace some warriors, these twisted body factories seemed unable to keep up with demand. Whenever they could, Scourge forces would take Resistance fighters alive, although most carried cyanide pills against this eventuality. Luckily for the Resistance, the Scourge judged the effort and number of hosts expended in a large offensive against the Resistance would surpass the gains in new natural bodies.

Instead, the Scourge seemed mainly focused on building vast numbers of a particular kind of starship. Quite small for foldspace capable craft at just 70m long, these sleek and sinister looking vessels were characterised by their almost featureless black hulls and, it became obvious, some kind of cloaking device. Resistance observers would watch these craft regularly depart the surface shipyards of Eden Prime and melt into the sky, bound for parts unknown. There were no records of such craft dating back to the disastrous fleet engagements of the invasion, thus it was concluded that these were not combat vessels. In any case, the enemy was expending enormous levels of resources in constructing hundreds of these ships every single year. The common conclusion was that these were scout ships, each a potential seed for an invasion against some other unfortunate species out there in the galaxy. Like seeds, most would never find suitable conditions, due to the random nature of the blind foldspace jumps that these ships would likely make once they cleared Eden Prime's gravity well.

Despite most disparate Resistance societies discovering at least this much knowledge for themselves, there was still virtually no contact between groups and no clear focus or plan for the road ahead. Most missions and attacks were opportunistic, fuelled either by a specific need or the chance to strike at a vulnerable target, often out of sheer spite. Any victories, no matter how hollow, were fantastic for morale and even the most dictatorial leaders began to see value in giving their subjects something to celebrate beyond surviving another year. This aimless but needful vengeance would soon be replaced by a definite cause, due to a single miraculous piece of implausible luck.

## HOPE FALLS FROM HEAVEN

In the year 2664, almost 160 years after the Scourge invasion, a bright and intense streak of fire descended from the void into the verdant swamps close to Eden's capital city, New Troy. A scout team was quickly dispatched by the local Resistance leader Karl Foley, a man whose name would soon become legend. When the team arrived at ground zero, they discovered the partly molten central bulkhead of a starship buried in the steaming ooze. Its construction, coupled with clear evidence of catastrophic plasma weapon damage confirmed that this was not a Scourge vessel. As no enemy follow-up party arrived, excavation teams were sent in and it quickly became clear that this was a human vessel of unfamiliar design.

Although the ship was massively damaged, a fragment of tungsten-ceramic plaque was recovered from the bridge, on which were inscribed the following words:

Almost no other meaningful information was recovered from the twisted derelict, but this scrap of intel alone was enough to send shockwaves of hope throughout New Troy's Resistance network. They were not alone, and mankind, somewhere, still had the capacity to build starships. This could mean only one thing - the existence of a human civilisation free of Scourge tyranny.

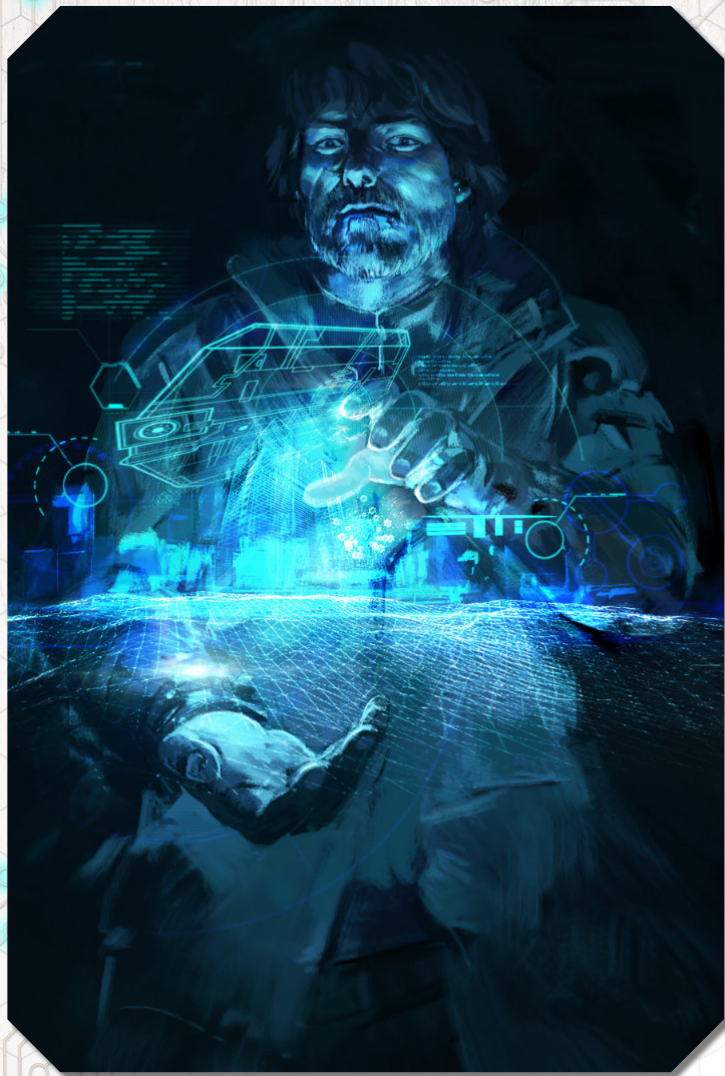
The most troubling thing about this discovery was the sheer improbability of it. Unbeknownst to Foley's men, there was not a single human foldspace node transmitting in the entire Eden system. Eden was rare in this regard, since Resistance networks on most of the other Cradle Worlds were able to keep a few nodes operational, in the hope of one day connecting with the rest of humanity. The chance that a ship would accidentally arrive close to Eden Prime, a Cradle World without a functioning node was beyond unlikely. Current UCM theories suggest that the Anastasia (which was lost on a routine jump between Maganum and Ferrum) must have been somehow sabotaged or led to Eden by an unknown belligerent, most likely of PHR or Shaltari origin. Whatever the purpose or reason, the fiery arrival of the Anastasia would change everything for the Resistance on Eden and would bring war on a titanic scale to the entire system.

## THE FOLEY PLAN

After hearing the news, Karl Foley felt that he had been handed a mandate (and indeed a burden) to act. At age 42, Foley was already the undisputed leader of New Troy's Resistance, a position earned through years of superlative generalship in the field and finally democratic election (a rarity) as Prince of New Troy (an equivalent of President for life). His men had discovered the wreck and it was up to New Troy's Resistance to spread the word to any other survivor groups that could be contacted.

First however, Foley needed a plan to present. Never a man to reach decisions in isolation or against the wishes of other respected characters, he requested an open council to help decide on what should be done. Strategists rightly believed that the Anastasia had arrived unintentionally and un-noded, as a lone cargo ship would never have jumped right on top of an enemy port knowingly. They treated the wreck as a random piece of incredible luck, pointing them to a clear way forward - capture a node and bring help to them.





The risks of any overt or large scale action against the Scourge were obvious, and immense. However, the fighters of New Troy were tired of being bottom of the food chain, and after three days of debate, a decision was reached. The Resistance would conduct an all-out assault on the central military complex of New Troy to recover the only surviving human-built portable foldspace node known on Eden Prime. It had been abandoned during the Scourge's raid on the tunnels shortly after the invasion, although strategists believed it to be intact, hidden in a deep waste dump below the base and likely overlooked by the aliens. This base was built into hard granite, so tunnelling in would simply not be an option.

Capture of this device would be crucial, as there was no more certain way to bring aid to the beleaguered planet than to light a beacon in foldspace. Such a cause would be desperate even if it were to succeed, as they had no way of knowing whether this mysterious human society somewhere out there had any desire to help or to try and retake what had been lost so decisively. However, the Resistance had been waiting almost 160 years for a chance at real hope and this, they felt, was it.

Such an assault on a fortified complex deep within enemy territory would need a concentration of human warriors not seen since the invasion. Foley's own band were not nearly numerous enough on their own. The first task therefore would be to convince any other leaders that might be out there to join his men on this desperate strike. In his typical style of personal leadership, Foley took command once again of his famous jumpjet squadron, Foley's Fearless.

The Fearless had been Foley's first command in his youthful days and had retained the name due to their daring sorties over heavily invested territory. Such an elite and specialised unit would be ideal for searching out and contacting other Resistance groups, something Foley insisted on doing in person.

After many months of risky missions, tense encounters and artful diplomacy, Foley's obvious ability and conviction won over many bands to his cause. Some had reacted with delight, some with grim acceptance and others with outright hostility. In one case, a local despot known as Salakahn tried to slaughter Foley's men at a feast, although he was wise to such a betrayal and the Fearless managed to shoot their way back to their aircraft. Despite such setbacks, Foley now had a force he believed might be enough to blast their way into the base and seize the node.

## THE GREAT GAMBIT

Once the talking was done, Foley had something approaching a real, full scale army at his disposal; however, very few leaders had been willing to commit precious ex-military assets. These vehicles had often become talismans to their people, with battle honours and tales of their prowess passed down through the generations.

Foley had made it clear that the operation was going to be a one-way trip for most vehicles involved as they would be abandoned at the scene and their crews extracted by air. Speed, surprise and aggression would all be crucial here, and while they may have time to drive stealthily to the target, they would have almost no chance of driving out again once the enemy's strength closed in. As such, almost every vehicle used would be replaceable, repurposed and weaponised civilian models - far from the best quality available, but crewed by the craziest human beings on Eden Prime.

As dawn broke on a bright summer's day in late 2665, the day of the attack arrived. Almost total surprise was achieved, as assets had been stealthily brought into position over many painstaking weeks. Finally, a frantic and headlong charge at the enemy marked the first large scale assault against the Scourge on Eden for 158 years. A spearhead of several thousand ramshackle vehicles smashed through the few Scourge patrols in the area surrounding the base and despite taking casualties at a ratio of 4:1 - this was but a drop in the ocean for Foley's horde. Once they reached the target however, things started to deteriorate rapidly.

Nine Scourge Annihilators that had gone undetected by recon teams announced their presence by raining enormous balls of superheated plasma down on the lightly armoured and rusting vehicles resulting in total overkill. Foley reacted quickly, sending large groups of his fastest missile-armed vehicles to take the towering constructs down. After sustaining crippling losses, the ominous machines were finally destroyed along with local AA defences, leaving the way clear for the Barrel Bombers to make their final approach. These were AT-77 Lifthawk dropships, modified to carry an enormous, homebrewed bunker busting explosives that were repeatedly thrown against the closest section of the wall to the target, eventually reducing it to rubble and clearing the way for the assault force to enter.



Foley's most elite troops entered the base on foot, readying their weapons for a close quarter fight with the occupiers, sheltering from the heat of the day in the cold confines of the base. Foley's veterans were largely equipped with plasma rifles taken from vanquished Scourge warriors and made the enemy taste the horrifying effects of their own technology. The enemy were concentrated here though and casualties were horrendous. Foley's veterans finally battled their way through to the recorded hiding place and succeeded in recovering the node from the depths of the base.

Once they had battled their way out, only 282 veterans were left alive from an assault force of over 2000. Gazing bleary eyed onto the bright battlescape of the surface, they discovered that the main force had not fared much better. The Scourge had responded with characteristic speed and savagery and were viciously cutting their way towards the centre of their lines.

It was at this point that Foley played his one and only ace, and committed the few armoured assets he had at his disposal. These were deployed swiftly by dropship into the heart of the fighting in order to cover the retreat of the brave warriors who had gone to war in little more than delivery trucks. The tanks of Foley's small armoured fist once again earned their reputation for extraordinary resilience and managed to hold the line temporarily but at great cost. Another wave of Resistance dropships quickly followed, extracting the battered vehicle crews, the remaining armour and, crucially, the veteran team survivors along with the node.

As the dropships raced from the combat zone, escorted by Foley's Fearless, the man himself brooded in his command chair. He had staked everything on this attack and had sustained appalling losses. Despite its success, this victory would be utterly pyrrhic if help did not come. It would be totally disastrous if the Scourge decided to hunt down the Resistance groups it had dispassionately overlooked. As the assault elements broke ranks and headed back to their respective home bases by secret ways, the Resistance of New Troy plugged the node into power and waited tensely for salvation or swift and terrible retribution.



## THE VOID WHISPERS BACK

For some time, no response of any kind was forthcoming for the Resistance of New Troy. Even the Scourge seemed to have regarded the attack as nothing more than a minor nuisance. Perhaps, surveying the field of wrecked Resistance vehicles and charred corpses, they had felt secure in their evident superiority. It seems that the Scourge were generally unaware of foldspace nodes of human origin, since nodes need to be scanned for by those with the right codes before they can be detected. It is likely that the Scourge would have hunted down the Resistance relentlessly were they aware of the real outcome of the raid.

Karl Foley meanwhile had been struggling to keep a grip on power and to hold his people together during two years of tense waiting. While his team had managed to sneak back to home base without pursuit, the elements from three of his allies' forces had not been so lucky. Scourge follow-up teams had raided their forward bases less than 24 hours after the attack, and had slaughtered the inhabitants without mercy. Enemy patrols had also been stepped up, making raids into the cities more hazardous than ever.

Many naysayers were keen to point the finger of blame squarely at Foley. The attack was his vision, and so far it had led only to more loss. The other leaders held their tongues for now though, as Foley had wisely involved them in the decision to act - tying them all to the consequences.

Finally, in early 2667, an answer came. One small human craft was spotted patrolling the vicinity of the node and was called down by antique pre-war distress beacons. The craft landed virtually silently inside Foley's swamp compound and was swiftly greeted by a delegation. Foley was there in person and was one of the first humans on Eden Prime to embrace a long lost brother from beyond the stars. The joy of the scene was palpable, as neither side had really expected such a reunion to ever take place. Foley's men marvelled at the 'cleanness' of their visitors, the strangeness of their accents and the utilitarianism of their craft. The black Raven-A light dropship was smaller and much lighter than most pre-war technology and was clearly designed for efficient orbital insertion. It had been modified for stealth operations, crewed by members of the elite Marine Force Recon, a small group of daring operatives trained for operations behind enemy lines.

After much talking, Foley's delegation learned that the United Colonies of Mankind had built an entire armada of offensively-oriented vessels and vehicles, designed solely for re-taking the Cradle Worlds and even Earth itself. This was more than the Resistance could ever have hoped for and gave new meaning and purpose to their long years of struggle.

New Troy's warriors, Foley declared, would be at the UCM's disposal and could provide excellent recon skills, years worth of carefully gathered intelligence and guides for the foreign commanders. Such advice would be sorely needed, since the Cradle Worlds had changed so much since the UCM's ancestors had departed these planets in terror. Foley's men would be at the forefront of this coming battle for freedom from this point onwards and became the UCM's staunchest allies on Eden Prime. Other commanders in other places, however, were not so willing to cede their grip on power to these foreign usurpers...



## A VISITOR UNLOOKED FOR

Elsewhere on Eden Prime, a sleek and altogether more advanced looking white craft came to rest outside the 'palace' of Salakahn, Tyrant of Altantia. Its crew stepped gracefully from its loading ramp, to be greeted by a circle of guns. They did not appear antagonistic, and communicated their wish to speak to the Great Leader. Such obsequious behaviour spared their lives for the moment and they were granted an audience with Salakahn himself. What transpired in that meeting was partly recorded by one of New Troy's spies.

Ever since the tyrant had tried to assassinate him and his men, Foley had kept a watchful eye on the brutal and cunning warlord. Some of what transpired in this mysterious meeting is of great interest to the highest levels of the UCM intelligence community and classified Level-6 to this day:

<<< The foreign delegation strode with quiet and controlled confidence into the inner sanctum of Salakahn. The stench of human decay mingled with more promising aromas of roasting animal flesh, spices and leather. After a respectful silence, a flawless looking woman stepped neatly to the front, and began to speak.

"Greetings Great Leader from the humble aspects of the Post Human Republic. We have travelled far for this meeting and must conclude our discourse swiftly, as those whose actions may disrupt our designs are fast approaching. We seek an alliance with you, most Magisterial One."

The speaker of the delegation gave a small, respectful bow, all the while casting her calm and somehow disquieting gaze around the squalid interior of what, she considered, certainly did not warrant the title of "palace". Charnel house, she decided, would be more appropriate; given the bones, trophies and beheaded cadavers lining the walls behind Salakahn's throne. She brought her swift thoughts back to the regretfully necessary business in hand.

"We can offer you silent support, supplies and above all, wisdom. War is coming to Eden Prime, make no mistake about that. We can help you maintain and expand your realm and have no desire to take your kingdom from you."

"What would you pretty characters want in return?" Snapped the imposing warlord in a gruff but surprisingly quiet voice for such a large man.



"There are certain... items which we wish to recover discretely from this world. We would also like events here to unfold as we have been advised that things must unfold, for the survival of all life is at stake. Some local knowledge and assistance would be appreciated and our overt involvement in such activities being detected would be unfortunate. Small things mostly, the occasional manipulation of events to..."

"Advised by who? What events?"

"Let us speak more about this later. For now, my... skills detect that there is primitive eavesdropping equipment transmitting in this room. I suggest that one of your men is perhaps not as worshipful as he should be..."

With that, she strode gracefully into the crowd, which parted before her in a trance-like awe. Such a creature of perfect beauty had not been seen on Eden for a very long time. Just as the crowd were fixated on this, she spun with balletic poise and roundhouse kicked a man behind her squarely on the chin, cracking the spine and ripping open his neck with the force of the blow. She advanced on the spaying corpse calmly and crushed a small device under her petite bloodstained foot, cutting this intriguing piece of intel short >>>

## HELL UNLEASHED - THE RECONQUEST ARRIVES

By the year 2669, the UCM were sending recon teams to Eden Prime on a regular basis, working towards preparing contacts, gathering intel and coordinating efforts for the coming offensive. Eden Prime would be the first target of the Reconquest, the UCM's titanic endeavour to recapture Earth and the Cradle Worlds. As the most heavily populated Cradle World, it was assumed that this would be the toughest nut to crack, besides Earth, and thus the treasured element of surprise was reserved for it. Even the mighty UCM did not have the manpower to invade across seven fronts simultaneously, so it was decided to focus on Eden Prime first. The launch date was set at June 6th, 2670 a symbolic date to match another auspicious day from Earth's ancient history. The countdown to invasion had begun.

One of the most momentous days in the entirety of human history began quietly for the forces of the Resistance. Some fighters struggled to contain their excitement while others struggled to keep hold of their breakfast. Most had been told what was coming only the night before to maintain secrecy and many thought they could imagine how it would be. The truth was that they had no idea and no way to visualise the sheer scale of the fleet now massing above Aurum, preparing to jump into hell's teeth.

The first sign that the invasion had begun was a deluge of falling, burning wreckage from hundreds or even thousands of stricken ships. No one knew if these fragmented remnants were enemy or friendly - no way to tell in such a molten firestorm. The warriors in their foxholes, tunnels and redoubts simply had to sit tight, stay undercover and pray that the UCM's fleet triumphed in the void battle above.

In reality, there was really no question that a swift and decisive victory in orbit would not go the UCM's way. Intel was good and the element of surprise coupled with a massive numerical superiority ensured that the Scourge garrison fleet was annihilated within minutes of the opening salvo.



A limited and precise volley of orbital bombardment was then unleashed, targeting those few areas that were both entirely Scourge dominated and expendable. Ultimately, a primary objective for the UCM was to preserve as much of the planet's prized infrastructure as possible, just as the Scourge had done. It was far better to capture a great city than be master of a pile of smoking rubble.

Nine hours after the UCM fleet had jumped into the Eden System, the first New Orleans class strike carriers began to break into Eden Prime's atmosphere. Each one of these craft carried over 120 dropships, around 300 armoured vehicles, a small fighter squadron and a full cohort of 1000 Legionnaires.

Although the UCMS Avenger had the honour of being the first vessel to break atmo, it would soon be followed by over four hundred more of its kind. Once the bulk landers had followed this strike wave a total of seven whole legions and five armoured corps were committed to the battle for New Troy by the end of the first day. This was over eight million men dropped from orbit in a twelve hour period - a staggering concentration of troops. An estimated 35 million human beings took part in some way on the first day of the Reconquest as a whole, over a third of the UCM's entire military and naval power.

Establishing a beachhead on New Troy and several other major cities was the primary objective for D-Day. With such awe-inspiring force at its disposal this was achieved with relative ease although casualties were beginning to mount as the enemy reacted to the sudden assault. The worst loss of the day came when a flight of Scourge atmospheric corvettes managed to break through the orbital cruiser screen and destroyed forty-nine strike carriers before they were stopped, seventeen with the loss of all hands and full compliment.

By the end of this day of days, the UCM were in total control of the outskirts and were beginning to push into the centre of the city. Estimated casualty figures for the first day at New Troy alone stand at 400,000 wounded and 350,000 killed - slightly higher than strategists had predicted but well within acceptable limits. Overall naval losses were much lower but still ran beyond 90,000 sailors lost to the void. Resistance casualties are still unknown but it is likely that they sustained a much lower loss rate, as their main job - reconnaissance and sabotage - had been carried out in the weeks prior to the invasion.

They were all effectively veterans of a lifetime long war against the Scourge and were extremely adept at staying alive. Despite this being the bloodiest day for humanity in 163 years, D-Day's operations were roundly declared a unanimous success.

## THE BATTLE FOR EDEN PRIME BEGINS

Despite the overall success of day one, the UCM high command was aware that they only controlled a small group of beachheads around some of Eden Prime's major cities. There was an entire planet to be won during this campaign and millions of men would probably have to die before its bloody conclusion.

The Scourge already numbered many millions on this planet alone, and who knew how many reinforcements were even now racing towards the system to enact swift vengeance. This would be a long and gruelling campaign, the first and possibly the greatest test for the relatively inexperienced UCM military juggernaut. The Resistance would be there along the way, mostly to help and occasionally to hinder the UCM's path to the longed for victory...







**JOIN THE RECONQUEST**  
**ENLIST IN THE COLONIAL LEGIONS**



# EDEN SYSTEM

FEB 10TH, 2671AD, D+250



+++ Classified level 2 - Senate and Ranking UCMA/F Officers Eyes Only +++

## OVERVIEW

### SURFACE OPERATIONS - EDEN PRIME

Although the Reconquest Plan as a whole is still in Phase 1, the situation on Eden Prime can be considered to have entered Phase 2. The cities of New Troy and Romagrad are now almost entirely under our control, although pockets of enemy belligerents are occasionally encountered. Our forces are now being re-deployed en-mass to begin the assault on the cities of the northern hemisphere, where the enemy has appeared to regroup.

The next few months of combat operations will be critical as the enemy must be entirely eradicated from all major urban concentrations before reinforcements arrive. A total victory here is essential for securing increased means of production, capture of resources and an Earth-quality planet to act as forward base. Troop numbers will be necessarily reduced during this period, as they are sorely needed to bolster the invasions on both Elysium and Shangri-La.

### SURFACE OPERATIONS - SECONDARY PLANETS

Eden II and IV are now entirely under our control. Scourge garrison levels and pre-war population were low on both these planets in any case. Fighting has only just begun on Eden VII which was a massive producer of raw titanium before the war and appears to have been exploited heavily by the Scourge during their occupation. AHQ estimates our forces are many months away from total victory here.

### ORBITAL OPERATIONS

Enemy fleet assets above Eden Prime have been entirely neutralised and not a single Scourge ship is reported present in the Eden System at this time. Occasional sightings of PHR

and Shaltari vessels have been reported although no full scale combat engagements have occurred.

With effective command of the void, the Admiralty will shortly request a large portion of Eden's garrison armada depart for the Olympus theatre, where their presence will contribute to the major fleet action occurring there. A picket force will remain to assist with orbital bombardment fire missions and to blockade the outer markers of the system.

## ACTIVE SURFACE BATTLEFRONTS

### CITY OF NEW TROY AND CITY OF ROMAGRAD - EDEN PRIME

Actions in both of these cities can be regarded as mop-up or kill team operations. Considerable concentrations of Scourge were eradicated several months ago. But, pockets of enemy forces remain and it is vital that reliable and safe control be exerted over these urban centres.

The majority of the Resistance fighters in these cities are known and trusted allies of Honorary General Karl Foley and can be relied upon to assist where needed. Gen. Foley has





requested a re-posting to the frontline in Atlantia and transit for his men, a request AHQ is in the process of granting at the time of writing. Apparently, he has a personal score to settle there and wishes to continue to kill Scourge to the best of his ability in the meantime.

### **CITY OF ATLANTIA - EDEN PRIME**

Fighting on Eden Prime is currently at its most intense around Atlantia, a city well inside the northern hemisphere. Scourge forces rallied to this particular city after their rout at New Troy and Romagrad. Enemy concentrations here still number in the millions after over one hundred days of continuous fighting and the city has already claimed the lives of two million UCM enlisted personnel. PHR forces have also been sighted in the area with several cohorts and armoured divisions reported missing in mysterious circumstances.

The Resistance forces around Atlantia have been uncharacteristically hostile to our efforts for freedom. This can largely be attributed to the aggressive partisan activities of a man known only as Salakahn, a local warlord of considerable savagery. Our efforts to hunt down and eliminate him have so far met with failure. It is hoped that Gen. Foley's arrival from New Troy will help to rectify matters. In the meantime, all non-Colonial humans in the combat zone should be considered enemy belligerents and dealt with accordingly.

### **CITY OF STAR-CASABLANCA - EDEN PRIME**

This is currently the only city in the warmer southern hemisphere still in Scourge hands. Enemy assets here are largely vehicle based, since Scourge warriors seem to find the high temperatures unpleasant.

The enemy have proved tough to dislodge due to the tight and maze-like nature of the streets, which suit their close range weaponry extremely well. We are currently facing insubordination and morale issues getting tank commanders to enter the city at this time. The UCMA has seen seven whole Armoured Corps lost within the city walls and patience is waning.

AHQ officers are currently in negotiations with the Admiralty and the Senate to break our 'Preserved City' policy and have the site flattened from orbit. If such an action is taken, we are beholden to extract the local Resistance forces, which have been instrumental in maintaining a thriving insurgency, utilising homemade anti-tank munitions with disproportionate effect. In the meantime, operations continue here in an attempt to capture and maintain a foothold in this death trap of a city.

### **CITY OF NEW ATHENS - EDEN PRIME**

This is the last city on Eden Prime firmly in Scourge control and unassailed. Its location in the storm battered far north makes it a difficult target for orbital insertion. It was determined from the outset that New Athens should be captured by conventional ground assault aided by surface launched dropships. Such an attack requires control of the smaller settlements surrounding the city proper.

Recon patrols are already scouting the area, although several have been reported destroyed by long range, hyper-advanced directed energy weaponry of non-Scourge origin. It is suspected that a Shaltari force is attempting to disrupt our operations here for reasons unknown.

### **ODIN'S FOUNDRY - EDEN PRIME**

Odin's Foundry is a local and collective name for the sprawling geo-mineral and metalwork plants clustered around Eden Prime's Mantle Scar. This 2000 mile long exposed fault line throws out billions of tonnes of precious metals and minerals every year from the planet's molten core. The Foundry has always been the key to Eden's manufacturing capability and its capture is now priority one.

Fighting is still intense along most of the Scar, although we have made significant gains in the last month. The arrival of new, heavier armoured units in greater numbers from Ferrum has hastened the war here considerably. The Scourge are still a force to be reckoned with in several areas and reports of PHR involvement are frequent, although they seem to be fighting the Scourge and our own patrols whenever they are encountered.

The Resistance here are particularly tough and some of the most diverse anywhere on Eden Prime. We have reports of everything from societies civilised enough to control several factories to tales of true savages, driven to insanity in their torment some are known to roast human beings alive in the thermal vents, consuming their flesh in ritualistic sacrifice. Any Resistance fighters in this region should therefore be approached with extreme caution.

### **TITANIUM MINES - EDEN VII**

These facilities are the last bastions of Scourge defiance in the System outside of Eden Prime. The mines are built into vast, city-sized caverns beneath Eden VII's twisted, frozen surface. These underground spaces are sometimes so vast and extensive that Eden VII could be described as a planet within a planet.

Combat conditions are difficult here due to the poisonous atmosphere - respirators are to be worn by combat troops at all times. Any form of orbital bombardment or support is also impossible here and the enemy is well dug in. The Scourge seem to have valued the mines highly and have reinforced the fortifications in addition to building several enormous constructs of unknown purpose below the surface.

An assault by mass dropship insertion into the caverns is planned as soon as enough craft are freed up for use after the offensive against Odin's Foundry. Losses are projected to be high and combat fatigue a serious problem. Issues here are compounded by reported PHR and Shaltari presence. The existence of any viable Resistance force seems unlikely, so we cannot count on any assistance in the tough battles ahead.



## SETTING GAMES IN THE EDEN SYSTEM (PHASE 1 AND 2) - DESIGNER'S NOTES

The narrative in the Eden system is currently the most developed, with a wide variety of battlefronts, locales and background. As such, this would be the most appropriate theatre in which to organise/set a campaign or series of games. Here are just a few ideas to get you started:

**1) Pre-Invasion ops:** Given the extensive background for Eden Prime under occupation, it's easy to find narratives for games set before the UCM arrive. Resistance vs Scourge matches would obviously be most suitable, but you could explore the activities of PHR or Shaltari forces as they take the chance to grab objectives before the UCM arrive. Karl Foley's 'Great Gambit' alone could be used as a basis for a series of games to recreate this famous battle.

**2) Recon:** These types of missions work well in almost every theatre as early scenarios. Intel based scenarios are perfect for early stage games.

**3) Establishing a beachhead:** 'Take and Hold' style scenarios (often those with Focal Points) work very well for representing a sector during a wider combat drop.

**4) Battles in New Troy and Romagrad:** Both of these vast cities offer a backdrop for almost any urban scenario you can dream up. Both 'clean' and 'overgrown' buildings can be used to represent areas that the Scourge have either maintained or left to rot.

**5) Battles in Atlantia:** This city is often snow covered; building a table to represent this battlefront would be an engaging hobby project. Scenic snow designed for model railway layouts is inexpensive and looks great!

**6) Battles in Star-Casablanca:** The best way to visualise this city is as a futuristic version of Mogadishu. Experiment with large numbers of small structures with low, flat rooftops. Fine sand can be used to add to the desert flavour of this city.

**7) Battles around New Athens:** Although the city itself is yet to be attacked at this point in the narrative, the surrounding towns and spaceports are a focus for combat. These operations suit games of DZC well, especially 'Take and Hold' style scenarios. You could introduce some house rules to represent the volatile nature of the weather this far north on Eden Prime.

**8) Battles in Odin's Foundry:** This location in particular calls for some creative scenery building! Many tutorials can be found online for creating realistic lava flows and other geological features. Re-purposed plastic bottles and other containers work well as bases for industrial structures.

**9) The Titanium Mines:** This location can be represented in a number of ways. They contain underground factories and can therefore use some of the same scenery built for Odin's Foundry. To really get the feel of this battlefront, a dark, rocky base should be used. Perhaps introduce some house rules to represent the toxic atmosphere and the risks of flying dropships into caves! Although the full assault has not yet begun here, recon missions are being conducted.

**10) Run a themed tournament:** An overarching narrative setting/theme can be applied to competitive games.





# ELYSIUM SYSTEM

FEB 10TH, 2671AD, D+73



+++ Classified level 2 - Senate and Ranking UCMA/F Officers Eyes Only +++

## OVERVIEW

Elysium Prime was once the bread basket of over half the human race and features the most fertile soil and largest viable area of agricultural land anywhere yet discovered in the galaxy. Such characteristics make Elysium Prime essential if our race is to eventually repopulate back to pre-war levels. Our own colony of Maganum, productive though it is, is merely a pale shadow of this verdant agri-paradise.

The millions upon millions of Scourge hosts infecting the Cradle Worlds need carbohydrate just as we do, and Elysium Prime seems to fulfil the same role for them as it did for us. Cutting a large proportion of the enemy's food supply while vastly increasing our own is a primary objective of Phase 1.

## SURFACE OPERATIONS - ELYSIUM PRIME

Like all Cradle Worlds, Elysium Prime features several heavily urbanised zones and it is in these areas that the enemy is concentrated and our operations have focused. It is now 73 days since D-Day on Elysium Prime and our campaign on the surface is progressing acceptably but slowly.

Fighting has so far been centred on the capital city of Triticum. An initial combat drop of five million combat troops plus support personnel have been topside since the invasion, although reinforcements have regrettably been siphoned off to other theatres. AHQ has insisted that this force will be sufficient to sweep the planet of all Scourge life and plans have been adjusted accordingly based on this assumption.

## SURFACE OPERATIONS - SECONDARY PLANETS

Elysium III and IV (inhospitable rocks) both featured precious gem mines before the war. These were high value assets in peacetime and supplied the majority of humanity's jewellery trade with rubies, sapphires and emeralds. The Scourge seem not to have valued this resource highly since they flattened the mines by orbital bombardment during their invasion.

These planets are now under our control but it will take many years to rebuild the industry here - such decorative foibles are extremely low on our priority list in any case. Our own colony of Platina was always the richer supplier of diamond, a gemstone of much greater use in the war industry.

## ORBITAL OPERATIONS

Enemy fleet assets in the Elysium system have been entirely neutralised and not a single Scourge ship is reported present at this time; however, our Elysium battlefleet has been subjected to almost constant hit and run attacks by Shaltari vessels from D+5 onwards. These attacks have yet to inflict major damage but are a constant disruption to void movements. Bringing the Shaltari fleet to battle is proving almost impossible thus far. Elysium battlefleet command has requested more fast vessels from the Admiralty to deal with this threat, although few are forthcoming, given the events in the Olympus system. For now, this piratical enemy activity will act to further slow our progress in this crucial system.





## ACTIVE SURFACE BATTLEFRONTS

### CITY OF TRITICUM - ELYSIUM PRIME

The capital city is currently completely surrounded by our forces and the push towards the centre has begun. By far the largest city on the planet, this has been the focus of the fighting since the outset of the campaign.

Unlike on Eden Prime, the Scourge have repeatedly sent rapid relief forces from elsewhere on the planet to try and break our encirclement. These efforts have so far met with failure, although strikes against the western district salient are currently stretching our troops to the limit. An enemy breakout here would be disastrous as we currently have an estimated 45% of the entire planet's Scourge forces pinned inside the city limits. Urgent requests for more air support against these roving relief forces are frequently denied due to the Shaltari disruption of our fleet.

Resistance forces in and around Triticum are largely sympathetic to our efforts and can normally be expected to lend their support and expertise to the cause. The population is uncharacteristically well nourished here but are few in number. The relative lack of underground spaces in the city resulted in almost total losses during the invasion and the current free population are descended from a tiny handful of survivors.

### CITY OF GRANUM - ELYSIUM PRIME

As Elysium Prime's second city and main food processing centre, the capture of Granum is our second Phase 1 objective. So far, efforts to begin the offensive in full have been stalled by delays elsewhere in the theatre. Currently, expeditionary dropship assaults are being sent in daily to test the defences, achieve preparatory objectives and liaise with friendly Resistance fighters. Regrettably, several local warlords have declared their open hostility to any force entering their subterranean realms, we understand these areas have been fought over brutally for the last century or so. Our forces have been ordered to give no quarter should they be fired upon.

## SETTING GAMES IN THE ELYSIUM SYSTEM (PHASE 1) - DESIGNER'S NOTES

The operation in the Elysium System is at an earlier stage than that of the Eden System, although there are still plenty of areas in which to set games, all of which are in strategic flux. Here are a few ideas:

**1) Battles in the fields:** DZC is designed for urban combat and is not generally suited to open battlefields, but, adding some food processing, storage facilities of farmstead complexes can quickly make an agri-battlefield suitable. A variety of missions are possible here - your forces could be attempting to capture these facilities or destroy them to deny recourses to the enemy.

**2) Games in Triticum:** This is Elysium Prime's main city and should be the focus of most campaigns set here at this point in the narrative. 'Standard' urban-type scenarios will work well, perhaps with a focus towards dislodging a well dug-in enemy.

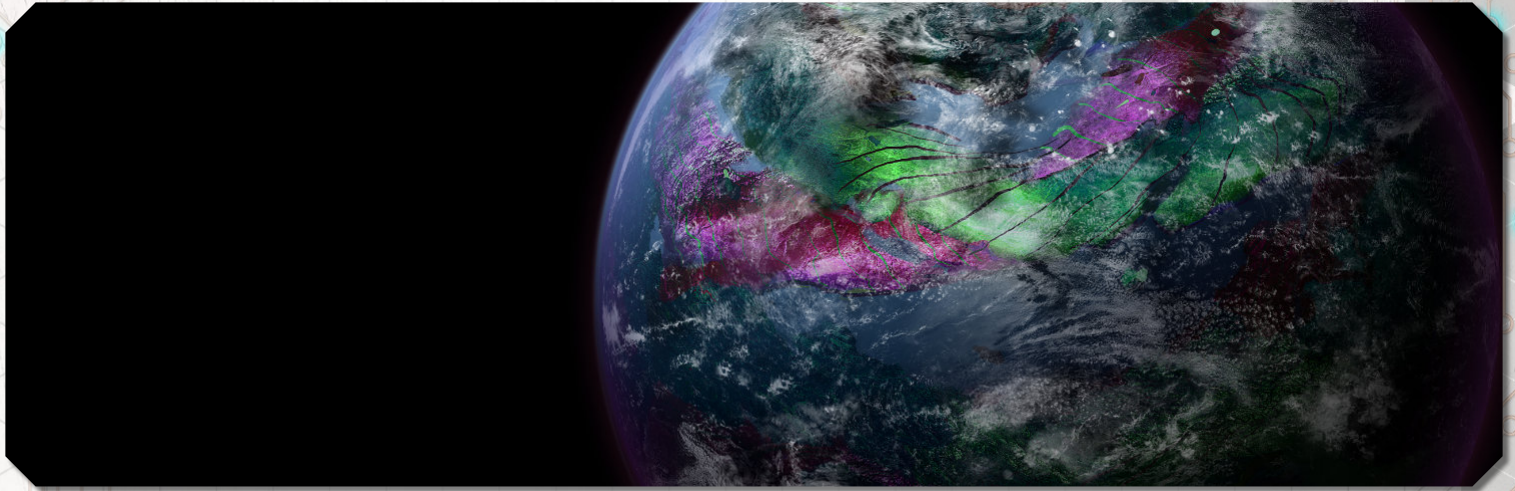
**3) Games in Granum:** As the planet's main food processing centre, games centred on this industry would be highly suitable. You could use some of the same scenery as for games set in the fields, saving some time.

**4) Food raids:** The Resistance in particular will have many reasons to assault food related facilities, as even on this abundant planet many are close to starvation. Special scenarios using truck convoys would represent this effectively.



# SHANGRI-LA SYSTEM

FEB 10TH, 2671AD, D+5



+++ Classified level 2 - Senate and Ranking UCMA/F Officers Eyes Only +++

## OVERVIEW

The planet Shangri-La was named for its breathtaking beauty. Its natural state was described as Heaven in reality, possibly the most visually stunning of all the Cradle Worlds with its lush flower groves as tall as redwoods, mile long sapphire cascades and fauna seemingly designed to be harmless and yet striking.

Shangri-La had been the focus of the pre-war tourist industry for affluent citizens of all the Cradle Worlds and Earth itself. It was also the main source of decorative flora exports (at fabulous expense) to the parties and mansions of the super-rich. As such, Shangri-La has many over-sized spaceports which once catered for over two billion tourists a year.

The Scourge have since had little use for the pleasure complexes and hotel palaces which have been left to rot and become stunningly overgrown. The spaceport cities however have been of considerable utility to the enemy. Shangri-La was never exploited for minerals as the other Cradle Worlds were and sadly, the Scourge have done so with gusto. Many once breathtaking vistas are now marred by vast mine workings, cutting deeply into the crust to access the planets staggering mineral wealth.

The Shangri-La system has only two other inhabited planets, Helen and Persephone. Both are similarly striking and feature flora and fauna from the same evolutionary source as Shangri-La itself. These two planets are quite small, and feature a gravity state of G0.6 and oxygen-rich atmospheres. This has led to gigantified variants of Shangrilanian biology. Half-mile high trees, insects the size of cars and blooms larger than a Condor dropship are commonplace. Unlike Shangri-La though, these planets also feature an incredible variety of poisonous, carnivorous or otherwise deadly predators. With less lethal planets at its disposal, mankind never attempted to settle on these worlds.

## SURFACE OPERATIONS - SHANGRI-LA

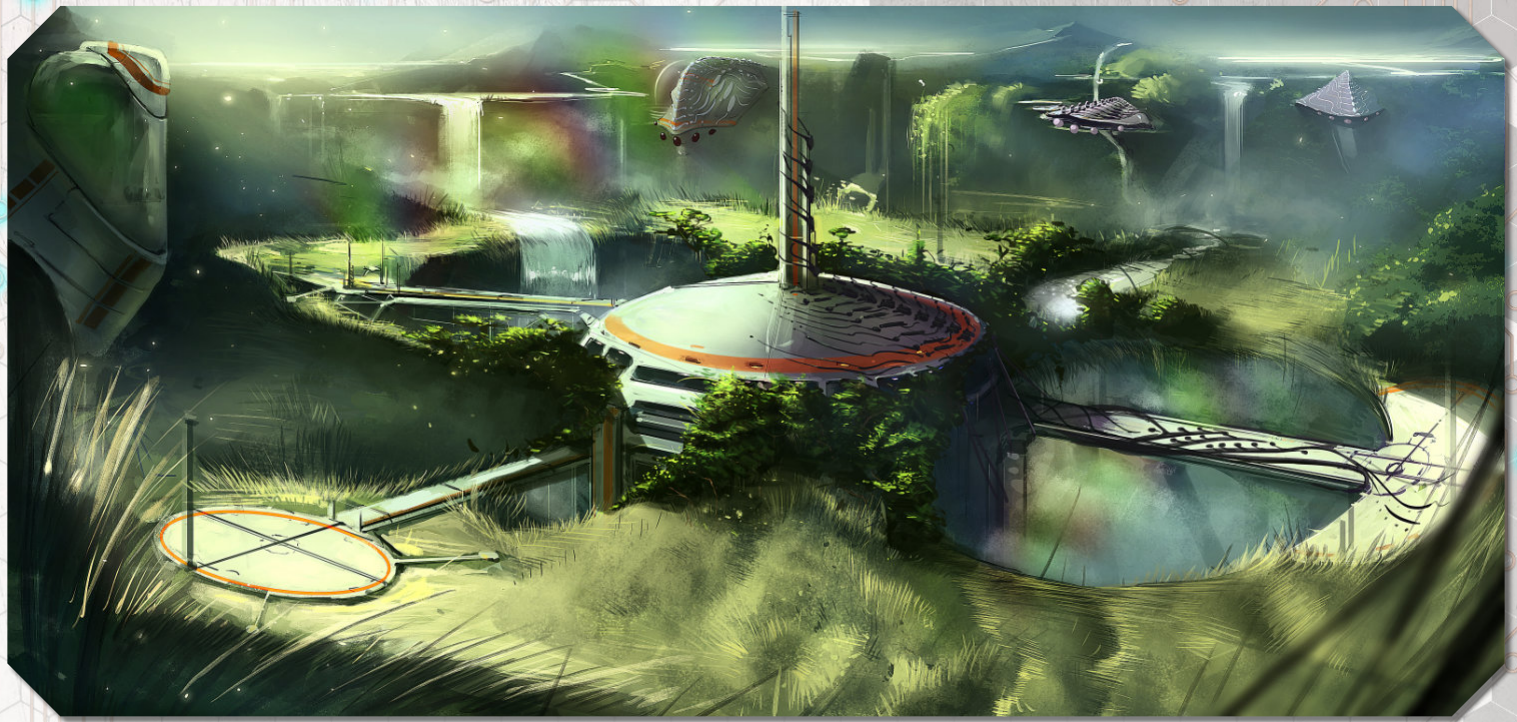
Capture of the spaceport cities has so far been our primary objective. The first troops made planetfall just five days ago and the situation is still very much in flux. Scourge forces are defending every inch of ground tenaciously and the anti-air defences around the spaceports have been the most extensive and fearsome we have yet encountered. Since this operation was launched 245 days after our first waves landed on Eden, the enemy has had plenty of time to prepare for the coming assault. Strike force losses were appallingly high compared to previous campaigns, although our superior numbers eventually told and a permanent beachhead has been established. It is hoped that our troops will soon be able to break out from the cities and begin their assaults on the mine complexes. Casualties estimates and planning have been adjusted accordingly based on this assumption.

## SURFACE OPERATIONS - SECONDARY PLANETS

The Scourge seem to have expended considerable resources in setting up permanent bases on both Helen and Persephone. Several unusual structures have been observed and it has been postulated that the Scourge are looking for and breeding new and nightmarish hosts here. The Scourge have always done so with any horrific creatures they encounter, such as the infamous Razorworms and Destroyers, and it seems that these planets are rich sources of new terrors.

Orbital bombardment would be the obvious solution, although anti-orbital batteries are highly numerous here. It has been deemed that destroying these facilities would not be worth the fleet assets lost in the attempt. As such, the UCMA has suggested small, commando-style raids to quietly bypass the defences, reconnoitre and if possible destroy these facilities from the inside. The first such raids have just been given the green-light and army intelligence waits nervously to discover what new horrors may be lurking in store for our troops in this sector.





## ORBITAL OPERATIONS

Void combat with local Scourge battlefleets is still ongoing. The area surrounding our dropsites has been cleared of all enemy void presence, although ships from elsewhere in the system are joining the fight daily. A large number of enemy atmosphere-capable ships were destroyed whilst on the ground in the first hours of the invasion, thanks to sustained recon by the local Resistance networks and careful choice of the exact time of attack.

The outer markers around Helen and Persephone are still considered enemy territory and fleet actions are yet to be initiated against this presence. This is considered priority two while combat deployments on Shangri-La are ongoing.

## ACTIVE SURFACE BATTLEFRONTS

### SPACEPORT COMPLEXES - SHANGRI-LA

Shangri-La is unusual as it does not have a single city which matches those on the other Cradle Worlds for size. Instead, it features hundreds of spaceport and hotel complexes designed to service the tourist trade, dotted throughout the planet in secluded areas. Our knowledge of local Resistance groups is currently restricted as there are far too many disparate, isolated societies to get a clear picture at this stage.

Capture of ground is a difficult, piecemeal affair as this battlefield does not support the large operations we have prepared for. Instead, hundreds of smaller attacks must be initiated, sometimes supported by a single strike carrier. Battle here is a planner's nightmare and quick thinking and adaptability will be essential to victory. Sightings of PHR and Shaltari forces already on the ground have only served to complicate matters further. It is still only five days into the invasion and we are yet to see how combat in this theatre will develop.

## EXPERIMENTAL BREEDING HIVES - HELEN AND PERSEPHONE

The daring clandestine raids on the Scourge facilities on the planets Helen and Persephone have just been launched. Priorities here are firstly recon and secondly demolition, should the opportunity arise. The first raids have successfully snuck past the enemy screen and are making planetfall as we speak. Await further reports.

## SETTING GAMES IN THE SHANGRI-LA SYSTEM (PHASE 1 ) - DESIGNER'S NOTES

The operation in the Shangri-La System is currently at a very early stage of invasion, with large scale troop drops still taking place. This makes it a great place to set a campaign where the results of each game have a big effect on the next game, since the progress of the operation is not yet defined. Some ideas for setting games here are as follows:

**1) Vibrant Scenery:** Shangri-La is a botanically diverse and attractive locale in which to set games. Although it does have cities (which will look mostly like those elsewhere), overgrown areas should look extra-verdant with an abundance of colourful blooms and outlandish plants. Try adding a splash of colour to foliage with targeted brush painting and adding extra foliage - a wide range is usually available from hobby shops.

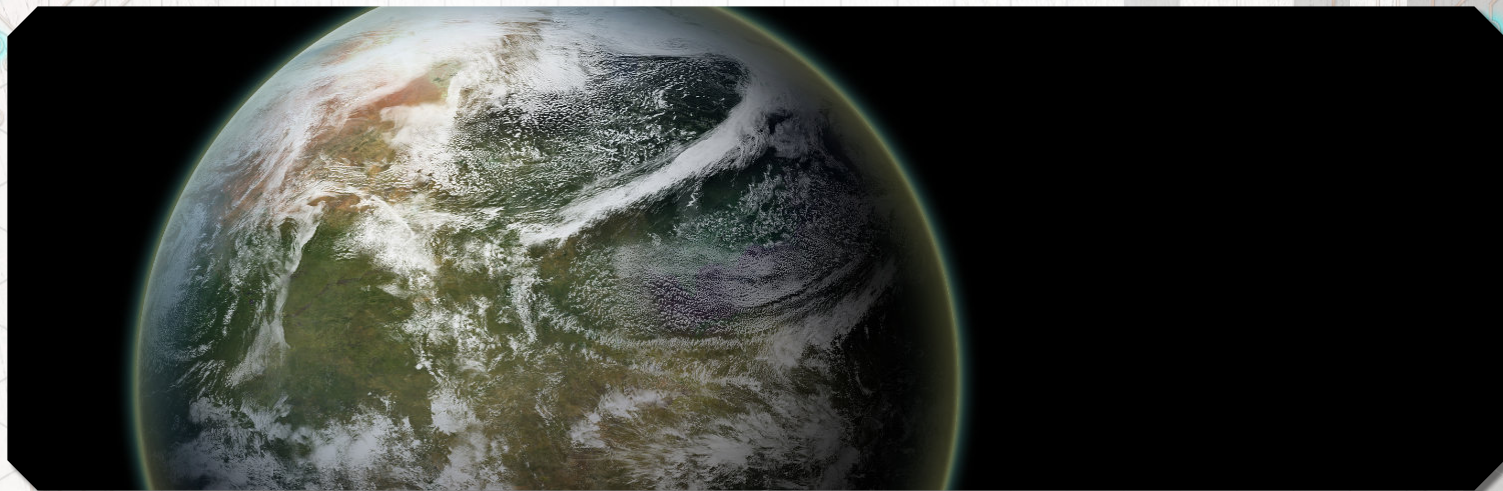
**2) Spaceport hopping:** The battle for Shangri-La will revolve around its large number of small spaceports. These are perfect settings for DZC sized games where a complete attack can be represented. Since there are large numbers of these, virtually the same scenery could be used/ revised for each game, saving hobby time for painting miniatures!

**3) Games on Helen and Persephone:** The small recon/ demolition raids sent to these dangerous worlds make for excellent themed DZC games. Try using fake flowers to represent the mega-flora here. Also consider introducing house rules for the low gravity or for deadly super-predators capable of biting a tank in half!



# OLYMPUS SYSTEM

FEB 10TH, 2671AD, D-UNSPECIFIED



+++ Classified level 3 - Senate and Admiralty L3+ Staff Eyes Only +++

## OVERVIEW

Olympus Prime was arguably the least visually attractive Cradle World, although it was unquestionably the richest in natural recourses. Mountains of ore, open seams of precious metals, underground seas of hydrocarbons and buried Uranium deposits were all present in abundance. This led to Olympus Prime's rapid industrialisation, eventually eclipsing Earth as humanity's premier factory planet.

Everything from pre-fabricated structures to tanks were built on Olympus Prime during its heyday and it was also the largest exporter of raw materials in all of mankind's domains. First and foremost though, Olympus Prime was humanity's number one manufacturer of starships and became surrounded by spacedocks and orbital platforms of colossal scale rivalled only by those of Earth. There is no doubt that had the Scourge invasion not occurred, it would have overtaken Earth's orbital tonnage within another forty years.

Olympus Prime's home fleet was caught completely by surprise when the Scourge invaded with most ships destroyed in dock. Such easy targets allowed for precision fire and the docks themselves were deliberately spared. The Scourge then converted the enormous structures for their own use. Before the UCM opened its campaign in the Olympus sector, these orbitals were home to the largest Scourge fleet known outside of Earth's solar system.

## ORBITAL OPERATIONS

The battle for the void around Olympus Prime has been the largest and most costly orbital battle in the UCM's history. The majority of our fleet's offensive capability was unleashed here over nine days ago and battle still rages. Enemy reinforcements continue to arrive in waves and without warning, selling their lives by the thousand to dent

our progress. This engagement was projected to last a little over 48 hours but it is still ongoing. It has so far cost the fleet over 120 capital ships including 32 battleships and 3 dreadnaughts, with heavy losses projected to continue for the next five days at least.

The battlespace within Olympus Prime's outer marker has been declared closed to non-combat vessels, which includes the UCMA's bulk landers by which the majority of their ground assets make planetfall. Although strike carriers and their motherships are capable of surviving their numbers are too few to mount a full scale invasion. They are designed for fast tactical missions and first wave assaults and we simply do not have the numbers required to land the seven million men projected to be required for the invasion. As such, this has been postponed until we are victorious in the void.

## SURFACE OPERATIONS - OLYMPUS PRIME

Due to the vast enemy orbital presence, it has been virtually impossible to get many observers and scouts behind enemy lines and onto the planet itself. As such, we know virtually nothing about Resistance forces on the surface (if indeed there are any). What we do know is that a large PHR force appears to already be battling the Scourge around Asphodel, the planet's capital. How they were able to get past the orbital screen we do not yet know, nor do we know exactly when this battle began. Our forces should prepare to face PHR as well as Scourge adversaries when they eventually make planetfall.

## SURFACE OPERATIONS - SECONDARY PLANETS

The Olympus system contains three other planets with viable objectives on the surface, Olympus II, V and IX. These have all now been reclassified as Phase-2 objectives due to the difficulties we are facing in initiating D-Day on Olympus Prime.



## ACTIVE SURFACE BATTLEFRONTS

### EAA FLEET YARDS - OLYMPUS PRIME ORBITALS

AHQ has requested the use of our strike carrier fleet to land ground forces inside the orbital platforms themselves. These enormous structures feature enclosed, cavernous interiors with atmosphere designed for starships and are highly suitable for infantry and armour insertion by dropship. Such a daring plan has resulted from our inability to deal with the weapons grid elements on these platforms while we combat the Scourge fleet. With the ground invasion postponed these assets are available for use and the High Council has authorised this radical change of plan. The attack is scheduled for two days time, once we have repositioned the assets.

### ORBITAL DEFENCE GRID - STYX MOON

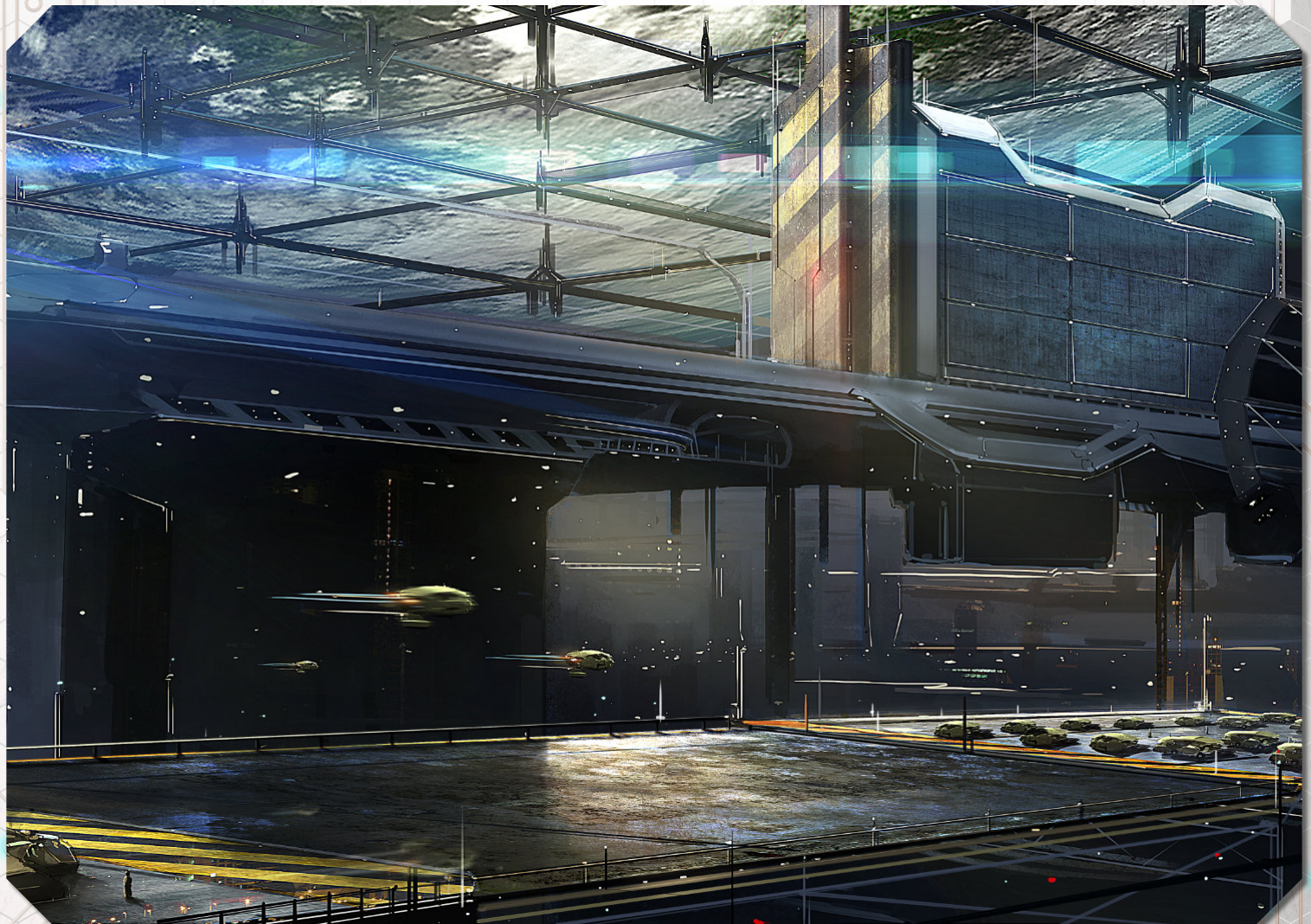
The planned attack on the orbitals also encompasses a landing on Styx (Olympus Prime's only moon) to attack the weapons grid control station there. Orbital bombardment is not an option as the facility is buried under over half a mile of lunar rock and must be accessed by air via the great canyon that runs half the length of the moon. Only fully enclosed vehicles are cleared for action on this front, as Styx has no atmosphere. The attack is planned to coincide with the strike on the orbitals.

## SETTING GAMES IN THE OLYMPUS SYSTEM (PHASE 1) - DESIGNER'S NOTES

Ground combat in the Olympus theatre is unusual in that it's mostly taking place in orbit! This creates the opportunity to run some very outlandish and highly characterful games. Here are some ideas:

**1) Battles aboard orbital stations:** The shipyards of Olympus Prime are vast. Many are large enough to have enclosed city-like regions. Games could be set here representing the forthcoming daring raids onto the stations by dropship insertion. You can use all the normal rules for urban combat in DZC, since these areas have artificial gravity and atmospheres. It could look fantastic with some inventive scenery making with an overt high sci-fi feel. Possibly introduce a house rule which requires all ground units to take aerial transports - you can't drive onto a space station! All sorts of other space related house rules could be used though- imagine the effects of capturing and deactivating the artificial gravity generators!

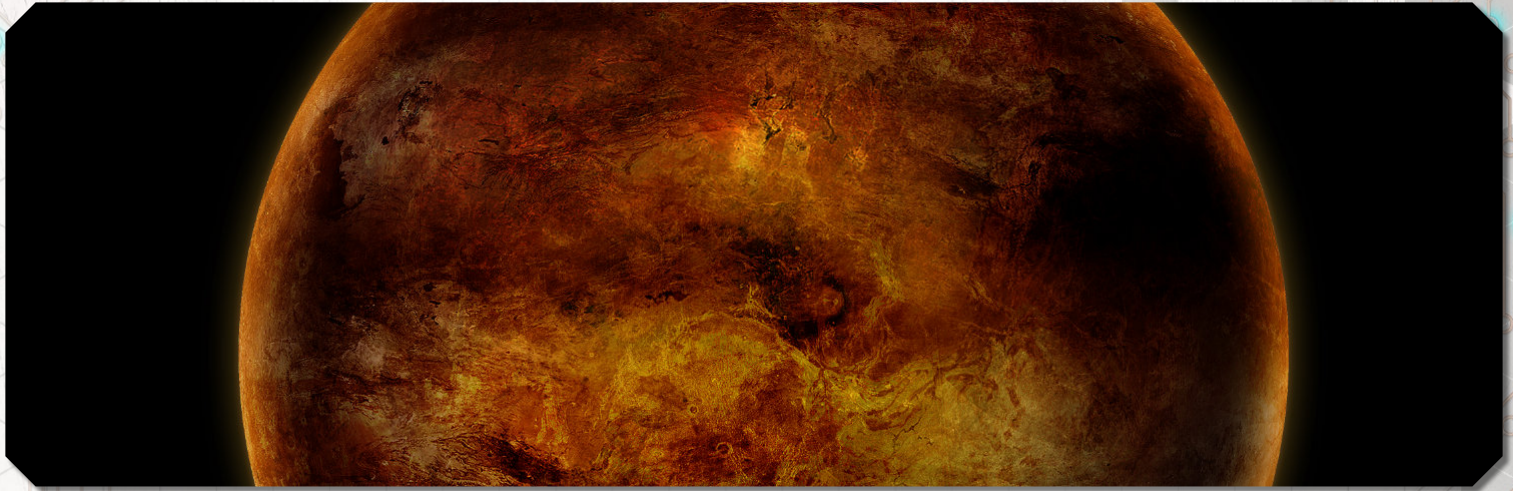
**2) Attack on Styx Moon:** Since this rock has no atmosphere, some special rules will be required. A simple rule stating that infantry must deploy directly into structures, cannot fire from the windows and are instantly killed if out in the open would be a good start. Also, damage to structures would likely be far more dangerous for the inhabitants! Consider using larger, tougher structures to counteract this.





# AARU SYSTEM

FEB 10TH, 2671AD



+++ Classified level 4 - Senate, Admiralty and AHQ Officers Eyes Only +++

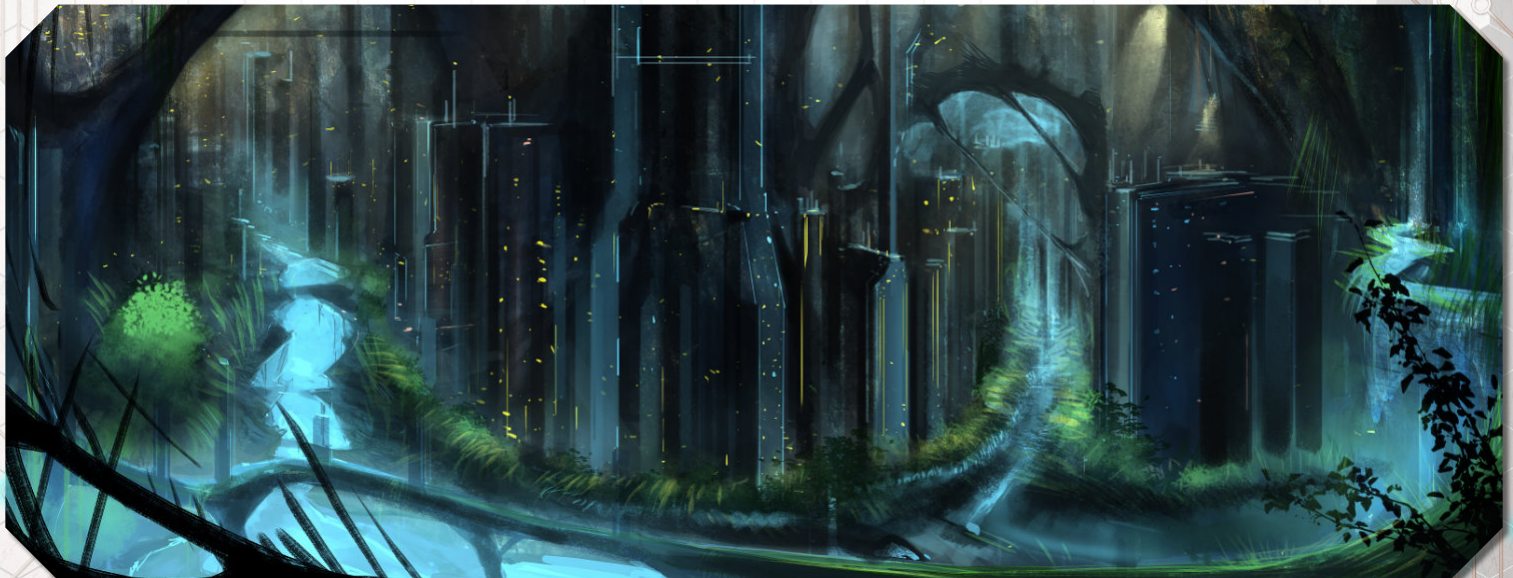
## OVERVIEW

Aaru is unique among the Cradle Worlds for three reasons. Firstly, the Aaru system barely deserves the title, as it consists of just a single sun and a single planet, Aaru itself. Secondly, its outward appearance is that of a barren, planet wide desert, however, beneath the surface is a maze of lakes and caverns so vast as to have their own weather patterns and a biosphere equal in splendour to the other Cradle Worlds (unlike our own colony of Titania, against which comparisons have been made). Thirdly, Aaru is the only Cradle World for which mankind had to fight before the Scourge Invasion.

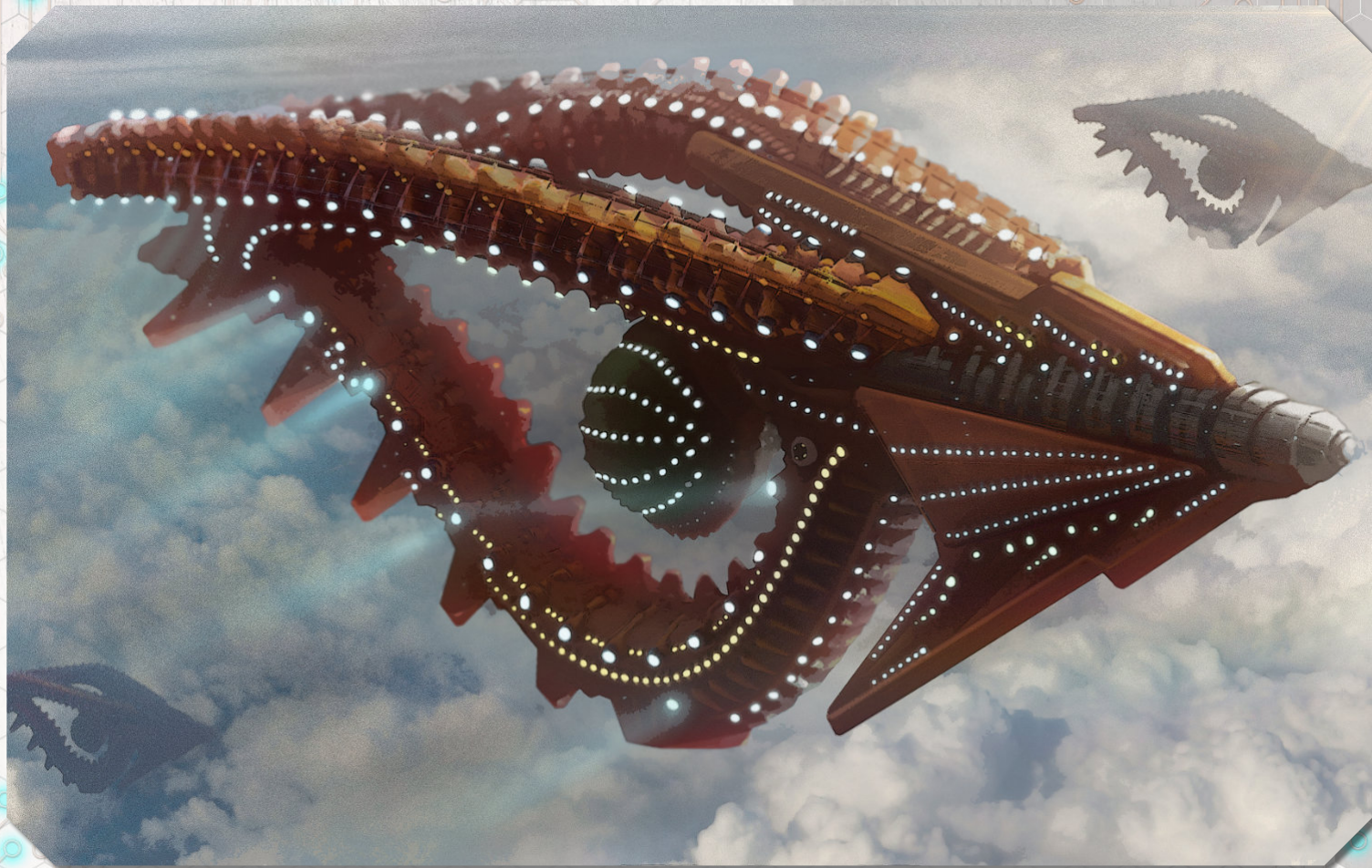
As with the other Cradle Worlds, Aaru was presented to humanity by the Shaltari tribe known to us at the time as 'The Friends' (now designated 'Apache'). When our alliance broke down, The Friends left us to Aaru quietly and peacefully. However, it seems that another tribe (now designated 'Mongols') had taken offense to our introduction there in the first place.

What followed was almost three years of bloody warfare against a far more advanced foe. The technological gap was even greater than it was at the time of the Scourge invasion, and modern historians estimate that the aliens achieved a 60:1 kill ratio throughout the conflict. It was as a result of the slaughter that Aaru gained the moniker 'The Land of Sand and Blood'. Eventually, our vast numerical superiority began to show and the Mongols were forced to depart in bitter hatred. Mongol forces have invariably done their best to massacre any human forces they have encountered ever since.

Today, Aaru is firmly under the control of the Scourge, with the vast majority of their forces concentrated beneath the surface due to the oppressive temperatures topside. Aaru's purpose to the enemy is currently unclear although recon missions are ongoing to ascertain this unusual planet's strategic significance before another costly campaign is launched.







## ORBITAL OPERATIONS

Our void presence in the Aaru system has been kept as low-key as possible. Lysander class lighters have made up the bulk of our fleet assets present in the system due to their stealth capabilities. These ships have been launching small recon missions to try and obtain a better picture of the situation beneath the surface and to make contact with local Resistance groups.

## SURFACE OPERATIONS - AARU

Contact has been established with several unconnected Resistance groups on Aaru. Due to the planet's extensive natural subterranean regions a higher percentage of humans seem to have survived here than on any other Cradle World. As was observed on Eden Prime, the Scourge appear to be unwilling to stray too far underground from their larger constructs or troop concentrations (although the main caverns must be treated as the planet's surface due to their sheer scale).

No specific strategic significance for Aaru has been detected as of yet. Although the planet features many industrial regions it is unsuitable for shipbuilding and very few 'Seed Ships' have been seen departing the surface. As it stands, the main objective for our forces should be the liberation of Aaru's substantial Resistance population, but unfortunately for them this ranks the theatre's military priority as low. For now, our forces have been assisting in an increasingly successful guerrilla warfare campaign against the Scourge. Our current priority is to tie-up enemy forces here sufficiently to prevent them being redeployed to other active theatres.

Although the conflict against the Shaltari here was something of a footnote in history (not even qualifying as a full scale war at the time), its memory remains. As such, it is not entirely surprising that a Shaltari force of considerable size is operating on Aaru. Their activities appear to be focused against the Scourge, although several engagements against human forces have already taken place. Their objectives remain unknown but we suspect that this world has significance to the Shaltari race beyond any other planet we have yet encountered.

## SETTING GAMES ON AARU (PHASE 1) - DESIGNER'S NOTES

Full combat operations have not yet commenced in this theatre. Yet it is an excellent location for some smaller games and for missions involving Shaltari, Scourge or Resistance armies who have all been fighting here for years. Here are some ideas:

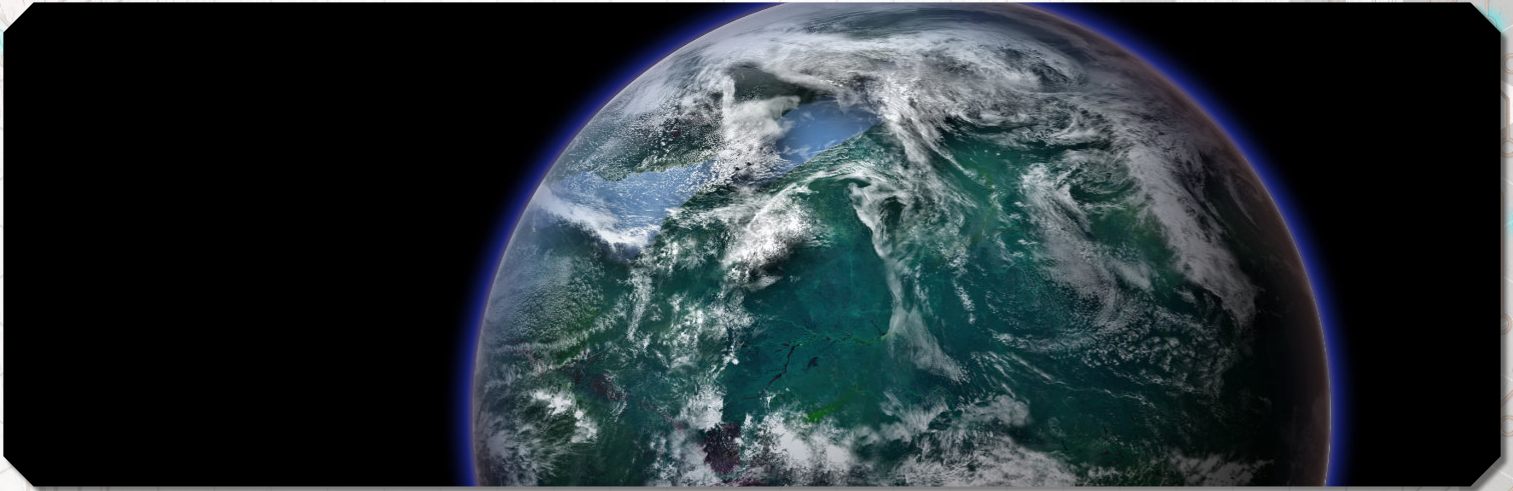
**1) Surface vs Subterranean:** Aaru is a world of stark contrasts. The surface is a mostly barren desert featuring a few isolated sandy settlements, whereas the caverns beneath are full of verdant plant life and crystal clear lakes. This allows any campaign set on Aaru to feature highly varied scenery. It would even be possible to combine both in an inventive double-decker gaming table, opening up the possibility for unique scenarios in the process.

**2) Pre-invasion ops:** There is plenty of conflict on Aaru even before the UCM assault begins. Games involving the Scourge, Resistance and Shaltari would be most suitable although the PHR is bound to be lurking somewhere with mysterious aims to achieve! UCM expeditionary forces can feature as well as they try to link up with the Resistance.



# ASGARD SYSTEM

JAN 29TH, 2671AD (LAST KNOWN CONTACT)



+++ Classified level 4 - Senate, Admiralty and AHQ Officers Eyes Only +++

## OVERVIEW

Asgard Prime is most famous for once hosting the largest tank and armour factories in all the domains of mankind. Many of our pre-war military ground assets were constructed here due to the planet's vast metal deposits including the most extensive sources of titanium and tungsten known to man. Only a small percentage of this natural stockpile was exhausted during the peaceful pre-war years.

Supply of these key metals on the colonies is beginning to show the strain of full scale war production and capture of Asgard Prime is considered a priority two objective for the Reconquest, since our current stocks are projected to last for a few more years at least.

We are currently conducting a large scale recon operation on Asgard Prime with a focus on coordinating local Resistance groups for our main offensive, projected to take place sometime next year, success in the Eden and Elysium theatres permitting.

## ORBITAL OPERATIONS

Our void presence in the Asgard system is minimal. We have a small capital ship taskforce in theatre temporarily, to shield a strike carrier based drop of a full expeditionary force (roughly 8000 men + armour assets) tasked with aiding the Resistance in their unusually successful insurgency campaign. This combat drop is currently underway, after which the taskforce will disengage and jump back to Niccolum before the much larger Scourge picket fleet can react. This small commitment of assets should contribute disproportionately to the general war effort while simultaneously presenting a minimal drain on resources.

## SURFACE OPERATIONS - ASGARD PRIME

The Resistance on Asgard are uncharacteristically well equipped with armoured units, some of which seem to be relatively new. We can assume therefore that some factories on Asgard are actually in human hands and still in production - an amazing feat while under occupation. The Resistance here also seems to be more coordinated and consistent than on other Cradle Worlds.

Our expeditionary force is equipped and trained to operate behind enemy lines for many months and has been assured assistance and the use of secure bases by Resistance Commanders. They are aware that they will be operating without orbital support or chance of extraction. Their combat doctrine will be to spread out into small cells within Resistance groups, providing a global command and control role across the various groups using the latest in communications technology. We also feel it prudent to report rumours among Resistance civilians of the activities of 'otherworldly types' or 'shiny characters' operating in small numbers around Resistance enclaves. Current speculation is that these may be PHR agents, although we are yet to have made a confirmed sighting for ourselves.

## SURFACE OPERATIONS - VALHALLA AND SESSRUMNIR

The two moons of Asgard Prime were also inhabited before the war, although the purpose of the installations observed on both moons remains a mystery. So much was lost during the exodus from the Scourge, including many of Asgard's classified documents. Current thoughts are that these bases were military in nature, most likely weapons research facilities. Scourge presence here is unusually high although we have been able to insert several recon teams. We are currently awaiting their reports.



## ARMY INTELLIGENCE REPORT: FEB 10TH, 2671 AD

+++ Classified level 5 - High Council and Senior AHQ/  
Admiralty Staff Eyes Only +++

This routine interim report is the last we have heard from any asset in the Asgard system - 24 hours after this transmission was conveyed, the lone and battered Lysander class lighter Leprechaun jumped back into our territory and within minutes transmissions from Asgard's three functioning nodes all ceased, making a return trip impossible for the time being.

The crew of the Leprechaun were confused and traumatised by recent events, which has been difficult to get a coherent picture from the 87 souls that survived aboard the ship. It had taken considerable enemy fire from non-Scourge weapons, likely of PHR origin. No other UCMF ships made it back to home ports and we must be forced to conclude that our small naval taskforce was annihilated in short order.

The general picture on the surface seems to have been one of coordinated, premeditated betrayal on the part of Asgard's Resistance. It appears that once our expeditionary force assets were in place they were attacked by our erstwhile allies and quickly taken to pieces. Many battlegroups were apparently able to escape the ambush net and may still be at large on the surface, although we have no way to tell as it seems the Resistance deliberately deactivated their nodes shortly after.

What purpose the PHR or Resistance have in these actions are unclear although such a coordinated attack certainly implies a planet-wide alliance between them - a disturbing possibility indeed.

For now, there is virtually nothing we can do about the situation on Asgard but speculate on the fortunes of the expeditionary force, behind enemy lines and surrounded by enemies on all sides. We can only hope that they are able to capture and reactivate a node in order to bring in reinforcements.

## SETTING GAMES IN THE ASGUARD SYSTEM (PHASE 1) - DESIGNER'S NOTES

Asgard is unusual in that it is fully cut off from the UCM at this point in the narrative. This makes the theatre particularly suited to inventive 'behind enemy lines' / 'survival' type missions and smaller games. Here are some ideas:

1) PHR activities - The PHR would have needed considerable planning and skill to coordinate the Resistance and turn them against the UCM. It is certain that they would have faced some opposition! This could make an interesting setting for some unusual scenarios.

2) Arrival to betrayal to escape - A series of games could follow the fortunes of the UCM expeditionary force as it encounters the Resistance, deploys and is mercilessly betrayed. This theatre offers the best setting for UCM vs Resistance games (although there will be groups on virtually every planet opposed to them!). The PHR will also likely be involved in the hunt for any UCM survivors.

3) Re-activate the node - The surviving UCM forces of Asgard Prime will largely be focused on finding and re-activating a foldspace node to bring in reinforcements, without which they are doomed! A series of games could follow the search and finally the attempt to capture one of these crucial devices.

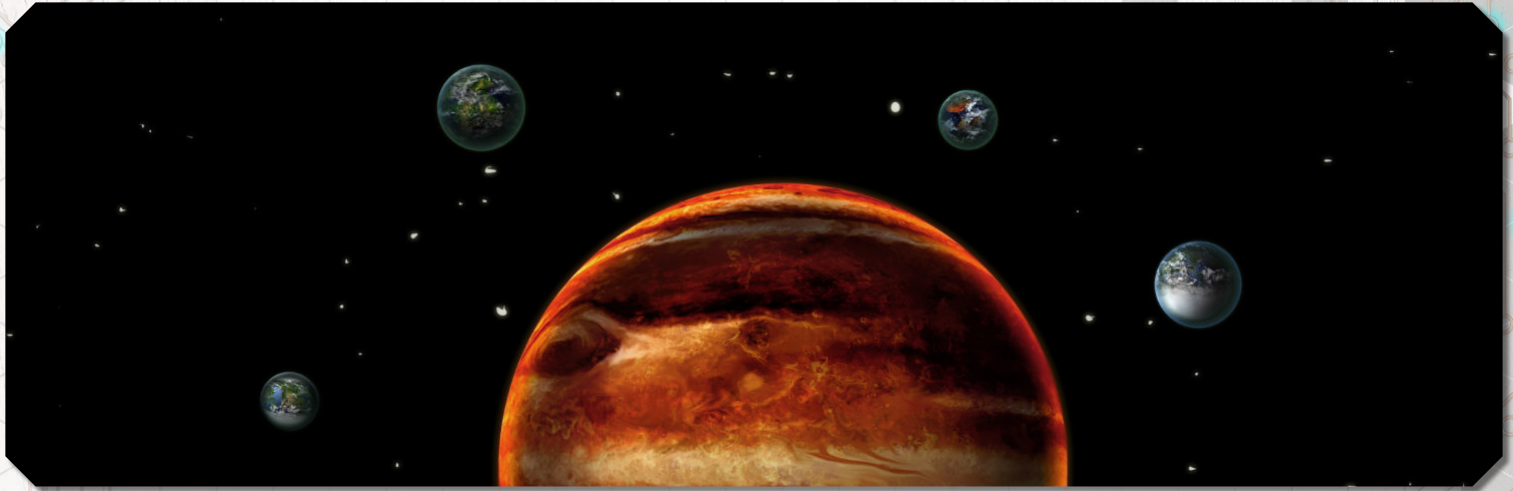
4) Recon on Valhalla and Sessrumnir - At the point of the ambush there were several teams present of Asgard Prime's moons. With the fleet presumed lost, these groups will now be stranded and possibly in even more peril than their counterparts on the Cradle World. These games could also focus on the secret weapons research facilities here.





# TALOCAN SYSTEM

FEB 10TH, 2671 AD



+++ Classified level 7 - UCMF Supreme Admiral, UCMA Supreme Marshal, Office of the President and Naval Theory authorised personnel Eyes Only +++

Madam President,

Further to your request for information on the Tlalocan incident, I feel duty bound to write a personal response. The situation here is extremely delicate and several highly experimental programs must be mentioned.

It is my belief that an enemy spy has infiltrated the highest levels of government on Aurum. I surmise that a member of the High Council itself is reporting directly to the spymasters of the Post Human Republic for motives unknown. As such, this document is classified Level 7 strictly for distribution to a select few individuals beyond reproach.

The PHR has begun a worrying number of military operations in almost every theatre of combat we are currently fighting in. They appear to have launched their own initiatives several days prior to the commencement of each of our campaigns, although this in itself is not common knowledge. The exact time and strike location of each mission, as you know, is classified to Level-6 clearance until D-1. To know the date and times of our invasions a spy would need to be present on the High Council as it is the only body cleared to view all Level-6 documents and make such decisions.

This issue will obviously require further scrutiny as a matter of extreme urgency. In the meantime, it explains my imposing of Level-7 to this document as the means to our involvement so far in the Tlalocan theatre derive directly from classified technology the PHR must not become aware of.

In brief, our Station Black facility above Niccolum has recently developed a miniaturised foldspace node (codename: Package Alpha). Previous technology required a team of six men to lift and a house-sized power supply. The new equipment can fit into a Praetorian soldier's standard heavy duty backpack. It is currently limited to five seconds transmit before its fuel core burns out, but this is enough if our forces are waiting for it.

This experimental technology was deployed for the first time in a top secret mission to infiltrate a PHR vessel and attempt to discover the location of their homeworld(s). An operative managed to evade discovery after a small boarding action over Eden II for long enough to be aboard when the cruiser Mind of Asimov translated to foldspace. We understand that she was detected and killed within minutes of translation, but this was enough time for the node to be activated and for our strike team to follow.

The team was one of our new Marine Force Recon black-ops units (MF-B). They had been at full combat readiness for months, waiting for such an opportunity. The window was so short that they only knew the operation had begun after their Lysander class stealth lighter Blue Shade had jumped to the new location of the enemy.

Unfortunately, the primary objective of the mission was not achieved, as the Mind of Asimov had not jumped to a PHR homeworld or other secret location. However, we inadvertently scored an enormous stroke of luck, as this proved to be the location of the Tlalocan Moons, the last remaining un-noded Cradle World system. The team immediately noded their location with a void based regular stealth unit and began an impromptu scouting mission. Their initial observations were conveyed by their ship back to Niccolum. The summary report is show bellow:



## MARINE FORCE RECON, BLACK TEAM 5: JIST BLUE SHADE, TLALOCAN MOONS, OCT 2ND, 2670AD

+++ Classified level 6 - High Council, Supreme Admiral, Naval Theory and MF-B authorised personnel Eyes Only  
+++

Jump destination of enemy cruiser *Mind of Asimov* is reported to be a planetary system consisting of a large gas giant orbited by four habitable moons. Database analysis shows that this is the Tlalocan Cradle World system - imagery is attached. We have been unable to raise specialist Harper's encrypted beacon aboard the *Asimov* and so must conclude that she was killed shortly after the jump, but was able to activate the self destruct mechanism on Package Alpha to prevent its capture.

Massive PHR fleet concentrations were observed from our jump location just outside the outer marker. At this time we estimate an enemy strength of over 200 capital ships including 17 ships of battleship designation and above. At this time they appear to be entering the final phase of full planetary assaults on at least two of the Tlalocan moons. Energy signatures suggest surface weapons fire on a massive scale. No Scourge ships were sighted, although scattered debris exists in large concentrations throughout the system.

We believe we were not observed during our first 48 hour long-range scan. Captain Johnson requests permission to return to the system to conduct detailed reconnaissance including surface ops. Supplies are currently sufficient for an estimated four months in theatre.

We await your clearance,

Communications Officer and Naval Theories liason Lt. Simkins (MF-B5)

I immediately granted clearance for a return trip at which the ship jumped away within minutes. The Blue Shade has not yet returned and we are well beyond their 120 day operational limit. The node they left behind is secretly coded and only accessible through MF-B for the time being. As far as the rest of the UCMF knows, there is no functioning node in the Tlalocan system.

At this point I intend to send two follow-up teams to ascertain the whereabouts of Team 5 and attempt to extract them from the system (with your approval of course). Teams 6 and 9 are being prepped for departure, stated to be a readiness within the next three days.

I have attempted to keep knowledge of this operation and the node of the Tlalocan system confined to my staff and members of MF-B on a need-to-know basis. The High Council is obviously aware as the team's communications were only classified to Level 6. Whether this is the reason for their disappearance on their return is unclear, although we must expect the worst.

I advise that this level of secrecy should continue for the time being. Our forces are currently stretched to the limit and cannot afford a full scale campaign against the PHR. Revealing this information would also require the unveiling of the MF-B program and Package Alpha. These are both key intelligence assets which should remain classified for now.

In the meantime, I urge you to move with the utmost caution and to only place your trust in those who have earned it beyond any doubt.

Your servant as always,

Admiral Chang,

Director, UCMF Naval Theories Dept.

## SETTING GAMES IN THE TLALOCAN MOONS (PHASE 1) - DESIGNER'S NOTES

The Tlalocan Moons are a murky, clandestine setting for spec-ops games. They are particularly suited to smaller missions, inventive scenarios, house rules and a strong narrative thread. Here are some ideas:

**1) The fate of MF-B Team 5:** This elite black-ops unit has not reported back to Naval Intelligence after their operational limit has been exceeded. Games focused on their exploits in the previous 120 days could encompass many scenarios. Marine Force Recon has access to most UCM military hardware, so regular armies could be used to represent the force. Some house rules (for example, banning Legionnaires and allowing Praetorian Snipers to be taken as infantry choices) would add an elite flavour to the army. A Lysander class lighter would have a very limited dropship compliment compared to Strike Carriers, but this would be more than enough for normal games of DZC.

**2) Unit experience:** Due to the tiny size of the MF-B force, you could introduce an experience points system to represent units which survive each battle and take part in the next. Perhaps, examples of rarer units (e.g. the Ferrum Class Drone Base) are limited to just one or two onboard - if they are destroyed, they cannot be used again!

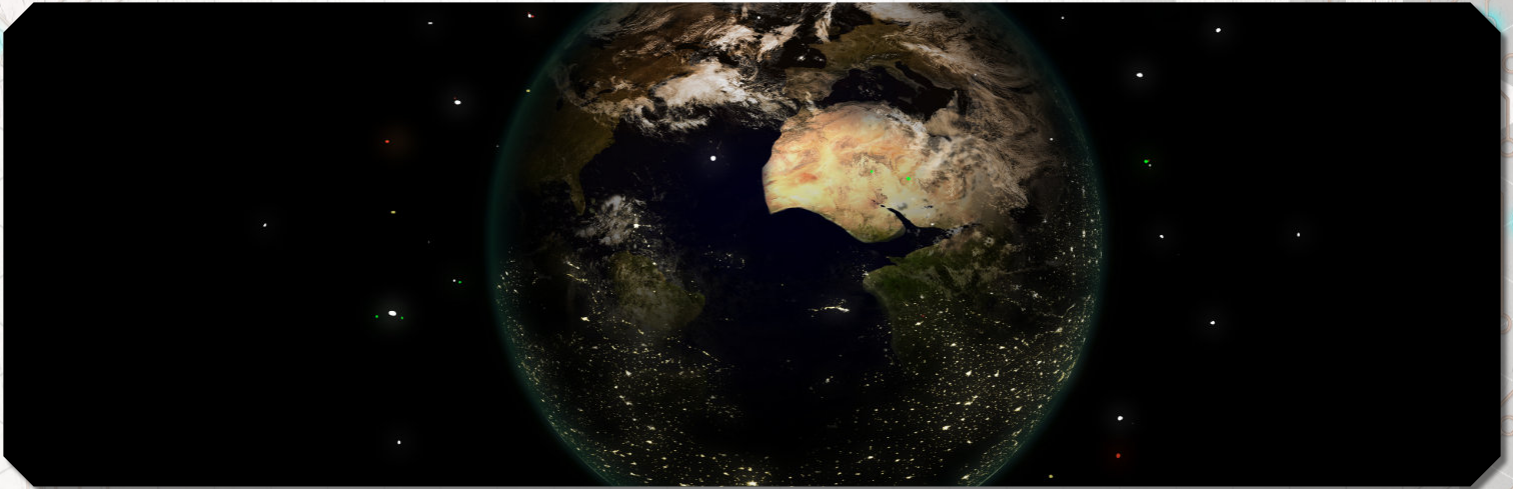
**3) Moon hopping:** Tlalocan has four habitable moons, the group effectively counting as one normal Cradle World. The recon team would have intended to get a look at each, allowing you to set games on several planetary bodies and to stage several orbital insertion missions.

**4) Follow-up missions:** The UCM is preparing to send MF-B Teams 6 and 9 to determine what happened to Team 5. This could be the basis for an entirely new campaign set after the first or could be used to allow reinforcements half way through the campaign. This would work especially well if certain units are limited across multiple games, as discussed earlier.



# SOLAR SYSTEM

FEB 11TH, 2671AD



+++ Classified level 5 - High Council and Senior AHQ/  
Admiralty Staff Eyes Only +++

After discussions on the reports received detailing our efforts on all of the Cradle World systems except Tlalocan (where the situation is unknown), the topic turned to the status of the Home Planet.

Thus far, we have conducted two operations inside the Solar System, one largely concerned with Earth itself, the other with Jupiter and Saturn. Our obvious priority at this stage has been to determine enemy strength here and to analyse the state of Resistance societies, should they exist. The first mission was launched shortly after the commencement of the Reconquest itself and was strictly a non-combat op. This mission was a success and its summary report is shown for reference below:

## MARINE FORCE RECON (MF-R) REPORT SUMMARY: HOPE'S SPARK, EARTH, JULY 25TH, 2670AD

+++ Classified level 4 - Senate, Admiralty and AHQ  
Officers Eyes Only +++

As soon as we jumped outside Earth's outer marker, our combat board lit up with more enemy contacts than we'd thought possible. Thousands of alien vessels surrounded Earth in a forbidding cloud. We even sighted two enemy Super Dreadnaughts, enormous ships not seen since the Scourge invasion. The excellent stealth systems of our vessel [Lysander class stealth lighter Hope's Spark] seemed to keep us from enemy attention and we were subsequently able to close with Earth.

We entered Earth's atmosphere and descended to drop altitude around the 17th [July], deploying six Raven-A/S light dropships [the 'S' signifying stealth modifications] to reconnoitre selected locations on the surface. I was included in the Chalk-1 team to collate our observations.

We discovered a horror-strewn industrial nightmare, unequalled by anything our forces had encountered on the Cradle Worlds. The Scourge seem to have invested more materiel here than on all the Cradle Worlds combined. While this would make sense given Earth's vast pre-war population, it makes the prospect of attacking this enemy fortress daunting in the extreme. Pre-war population centres such as North American and East Asian regions in particular, were hives of activity.

We were also able to make contact with several Resistance groups on the very first day by homing in on ancient distress beacons that had been kept operational. It seems that Earth suffered the most appalling casualty rate and lowest evasion rate of any population on any major human world. Due to Earth's bloated population, however, the Resistance there appears to be the most numerous we have so far encountered.

In the next three days of the mission we discovered many more terrible and enlightening things. Earth seems to be the main focus of Scourge Seed Ship production and the primary hub for breeding hives and host experimentation. We observed several Scourge hosts apparently unique to Earth as well as the largest breeding hive on record, a vast complex covering most of the region once known as Japan. Many more observations were made and are detailed in the full version of this report.

As our mission clock drew to a close, we departed the surface with many (often tearful) goodbyes to our newfound compatriots in the Resistance. It is at this point that I must also report the actions of a Lt. Colonel James Rodriguez, leader of the Chalk-4 team and ranking officer on the surface. It seems that the Colonel and his men made the decision to stay and fight with the Resistance rather than leave as ordered. Rodriguez and his team must now be considered AWOL - their transponders appeared to have been destroyed and we had no way of tracking them in the time available.



*I must admit that the parting of ways with the Resistance causes me great personal grief and a certain amount of guilt as well. Despite all our promises it is highly unlikely that we will be able to fight for the freedom of these poor souls for some years to come, given the strength of the enemy in this, our former homeland.*

*Communications Officer Lt. Braxon (MF-R 37th regiment)*

The Council concluded that a significant portion of the massive Scourge fleet described in this report has likely departed the Solar system to come to the aid of their beleaguered comrades in the battle for the void of Olympus Prime. As such, there is hope that if that grinding, attritional fleet action goes our way then the Scourge battlefleet around Earth may be critically weakened (at least in the short term). The general conclusion was, however, as Lt. Braxon had surmised - that an assault of the scale required to recapture Earth is potentially many years away and will require titanic efforts, dwarfing our current campaigns on the Cradle Worlds. The actions of Lt. Colonel Rodriguez barely drew a mention - a minor numerical factor in a war causing countless deaths every day.

The council then addressed the report of the second Solar system mission. This operation was launched recently and was also intended to be a non-combat op. This mission was a partial success and its summary report is shown for reference below:

## **UCMF SCOUT TASKFORCE REPORT: ETERNAL DARKNESS, SATURN, JAN 3RD, 2671AD**

*+++ Classified level 4 - Senate, Admiralty and AHQ  
Officers Eyes Only +++*

*Our primary mission was to assess the situation on the moons of Saturn and Jupiter. Our taskforce consisted of a pair of Lysanders, my own ship *Eternal Darkness* and its sister ship *Azure Night*. The *Azure* was assigned to scout Jupiter, mine to cover Saturn.*

*The situation around Saturn was pretty dire. We had expected as much after the reports from *Hope's Spark*, but it was harrowing to see with my own eyes. Saturn's moons had never been a massive focus of pre-war manpower but even these less than habitable bodies were crawling with enemy presence, both on the surface and in the void. Titan for example was mined extensively with extraction of liquid hydrocarbons was proceeding with ceaseless efficiency.*

*Reports coming in from the *Azure* were similarly filled with tales of enemy industry. Europa in particular now played host to colossal H2O extraction facilities. The Scourge need water just as much as we do, and apparently their biology is less tolerant of pollutants, making Earth's oceans less than an ideal source.*

*Both myself and my counterpart on the *Azure* were forced to conclude that there was virtually no chance of human survivors on any of Saturn or Jupiter's moons, as outside the enclosed bases (all now under occupation) the environments are hostile in the extreme.*

*Before the *Azure Night* could begin its sweep of Callisto however, we received warning from her: "Unknown vessel of cruiser tonnage closing fast, non-Scourge signature. Appears aware despite operable stealth systems. Attempting to retreat to outer marker and jump away - suggest you do likewise. Azure out." I immediately ordered a general retreat and crew to battle stations. Within minutes we lost all contact with the *Azure Night* and I must conclude that she was lost with all hands before putting enough distance from Jupiter to escape. We were able to breach Saturn's outer marker and jump back to Niccolum unmolested, thankful to have escaped whatever fate met our sister ship.*

*Capt. Ernst Brown, *Eternal Darkness**

The Council did not seem concerned about the enemy industries on Saturn and Jupiter's moons. The efficacy of both had long since been eclipsed by the Cradle Worlds and the Colonies - the facilities there could be levelled from orbit with little loss to mankind when the time came to launch an offensive into the Solar system.

The Council was far more concerned that an unknown enemy had the ability to detect the Lysander class stealth lighters we rely upon so much for intelligence gathering. It is possible that the unknown belligerent was already aware of their location through espionage or that the admittedly more advanced scanners of the PHR or Shaltari could circumvent our stealth systems. Either prospect deeply troubled the Council. Whatever the cause, it was concluded that we would need to be more cautious in our use of the Lysander's in future and that the moon Callisto would require further observation...

## **SETTING GAMES ON EARTH (PHASE 1) - DESIGNER'S NOTES**

Earth has so far featured very lightly in the narrative. The UCM have only committed tiny forces here and a full scale invasion is a distant prospect due to overwhelming enemy strength. Now that Earth's Resistance is aware that the UCM exists it will be focused on preparing the Home Planet for invasion and doing as much damage to the Scourge as possible, driven by new hope! Here are some ideas:

**1) The Marine Force Recon teams arrive:** You could stage missions revolving around the very first UCM personnel to set foot on planet Earth. Perhaps they need to be escorted to a safe landing zone over infested enemy territory or need to evade detection. It is worth noting that although the MF-R teams are certainly elite, they are not highly classified (unlike the MF-B black-ops teams employed in the Tlalocan system). This is more of a background point but may be relevant to campaign/list writing.

**2) The Resistance rises!** A whole campaign could be focused on the efforts of the Resistance to unite and prepare the ground for a future UCM invasion. They may be opposed by their own kind or PHR/Shaltari intervention and will certainly be hounded by the Scourge!

**3) The actions of Lt. Colonel Rodriguez:** Although he only receives a small mention here, it is likely you will be hearing more from this character in future... his actions on Earth may prove pivotal in the years to come!



# THE UNITED COLONIES OF MANKIND

Status as of Feb 11th, 2671AD (D+251)

251 days have elapsed since the United Colonies of Mankind launched its epic and fateful Reconquest campaign by assaulting the Cradle World of Eden Prime with irresistible force. So far, this greatest of efforts is progressing relatively well, with major operations launched against three Cradle Worlds in less than a year and Eden Prime is likely to be fully cleansed shortly. However, events have not gone entirely to plan...

## MANKIND GOES TO WAR

Almost total surprise was achieved and the rapid and merciless stratagems of the mighty Colonial Fleet (the UCMF) were able to reduce the enemy naval presence in the system to debris in short order. With total command of the void, strike carriers and bulk landers were able to drop over eight million men onto the surface of the planet on D-day Eden alone. Despite taking losses unheard of since the Scourge invasion, a firm beachhead was established and early operations declared a resounding success.

Since this spectacular start however, schedules have started to slip. The northern regions of Eden Prime are still mostly in enemy hands and early operations on other Cradle Worlds have not progressed perfectly. With the element of surprise mostly lost, the enemy had been preparing for the assaults they must have assumed were inevitable. After seventy-four days the invasion of Elysium Prime is progressing reasonably well (if slower than expected) and it's too early to make judgements about the progress of the Shangri-La campaign, as it is only six days since D-day there, although troops have successfully made planetfall.

## EARLY SETBACKS

The situation in the void surrounding Olympus Prime is the biggest concern to the UCM High Council at the moment. The Scourge appear to have chosen this system to make a stand in space. Unlike the other systems attacked so far, the enemy has thrown wave after wave of naval reinforcements at the UCMF, causing great losses on both sides. This battle is still very much in flux, with landings occurring on the orbital platforms to try and deactivate the defence grid, currently under Scourge control. This cataclysmic fleet engagement has resulted in other sectors being stripped of ships and the surface invasion of Olympus Prime being postponed.

Only small expeditionary forces have been sent to the other Cradle World systems at this point. It is beyond the resources of even the UCM to attempt to attack all seven Cradle World systems simultaneously. Of these recon missions, the loss of contact with the expeditionary force sent to the Asgard system is most troubling; as it appears that the PHR had a hand in the small disaster that occurred there.

Ultimately, no plan survives contact with the enemy, as the UCM military leadership is well aware. The failings of the Reconquest so far amount to minor setbacks in their view and the population at large is jubilant about its progress. Not a day goes by without news of more cities liberated, more enemy battleships destroyed and more scenes of triumph being shown by the state news agency. Whether this understandably one-sided propaganda will be enough to maintain the people's enthusiasm remains to be seen, although this will surely be tested as more sons and daughters return home in boxes.





## FRESH FROM THE PRODUCTION LINE

The UCM is constantly improving and updating its military hardware. Due to the rigorous demands of war and the civilisation's almost total focus towards the Reconquest, such innovations are occurring rapidly. Where pre-war designers would sometimes take ten years to get a design from the drawing board into service, the UCM has been known to achieve the feat in six months.

Most new designs currently making their battlefield debuts were designed before the opening of hostilities but are only just reaching the frontlines. Some aim to fill a particular niche. For example, the flamethrower equipped Fireblade light tank was developed as a response to the amount of close quarter urban combat the Reconquest was projected to involve. The existence of Resistance forces made such battles all the more likely, as occupied areas could not simply be levelled from orbit for fear of slaughtering thousands of fellow human beings.

The Ferrum class Drone Base is a particularly notable new addition to the UCM's arsenal. This monster was not created to combat a specific threat, but rather to create new tactical possibilities. With the Ferrum's drone swarms, enemy tanks and aircraft could be hunted down, all the while spotting for new artillery units, such as the Longbow.

Some units are appearing for the first time only recently, despite being in the arsenals of the colonies since the outset of the campaign. In the case of the Eagle heavy gunship, this unit was restricted to second wave operations as it is a high value asset extremely vulnerable to anti-air fire of all kinds. Only when the enemy's largest AA assets (such as captured Aegis ODLs) were neutralised could flights of deadly Eagles be permitted to enter the fray.

As new threats emerge and as the Reconquest plan enters its second phase, it is certain that UCM military engineers will continue to innovate, discovering new ways to inflict punishing losses on the enemies of mankind.





# THE SCOURGE

Status as of Feb 11th, 2671AD (D+251)

Although the Scourge have suffered some crushing defeats in the early days of the Reconquest they are a very long way from being a beaten force. Despite being assailed by the largest assault mankind could muster, the Scourge are still offering tennacious opposition in the north of Eden Prime and on much of Elysium and Shangri-La. The other Cradle Worlds are all still firmly within their iron grasp, and it will take enormous strength and sacrifices to wrest these realms from their clutches.

Meanwhile, the Scourge are enacting schemes of their own. Caught by surprise by the sheer ferocity of the UCM's opening play, the aliens have now had time to take stock and regroup. Wave upon wave of lethal vessels are at this moment being sent to thwart the UCMF's attempt to gain void superiority in the Olympus system. The vile aliens have already succeeded in postponing the ground invasion and a decisive defeat over Olympus Prime would be ruinous to the UCM's plans.

## AGEING HOSTS

The biggest concern to the Scourge, according to Resistance observations is not the threat of human retaliation for their past atrocities. The real problem eating at the core of Scourge strength appears to be the relentless ticking of biological clocks. Although Scourge neuroparasite implantation halts the ageing of the host, the parasite itself is not immortal. UCM astrobiologists estimate that the Scourge's natural lifetime rarely exceeds 200 years, although this is just an extrapolated figure based on the final deterioration of the previous hosts, the lizard warriors, compared the state of human hosts. Only another forty or so years will truly reveal whether this hypothesis is accurate.

It is beyond doubt, however, that Scourge hosts taken at the time of the invasion are beginning to show signs of parasite ageing. These include uncontrolled jerky movements, increased thirst and total loss of skin pigmentation. If anything though, these physical changes make such hosts even more dangerous, as the symptoms include a marked increase in savagery.





Taking new hosts is obviously the answer to this approaching crisis, although this is presenting its own hurdles. Hunting down the Resistance seems to have been deemed an inefficient use of resources, as the Scourge would likely lose more hosts than they would gain in such an endeavour. The aliens' principle driving factor seems to be to increase in numbers at the expense of all other concerns. Finding hosts for fresh hatchlings rather than consigning them to an existence fused to a vehicle also seems to be an imperative. Perhaps the second option is unpleasant or it meets with failure more often than success - maybe every Scourge war machine has had dozens, even hundreds of young die so that one may eventually meld.

To combat the onset of host death and the need for new hosts, the Scourge have been perusing two separate schemes. The first involves the mass vat-borne creation of human bodies to infest. This process seems to have a high flaw rate and looks to be inadequate for maintaining Scourge numbers, although better than when applied to other hosts (such as Razorworms), which can only be created through slow breeding.

## SEEDS SOWN

The second Scourge effort to find new hosts seems to be focused around the construction of a vast number of special starships, equipped with the rare technology of a cloaking device. These ships have been leaving Cradle World and Earth airspace in their hundreds for many years, bound for parts unknown. The present theory is that these make random unguided foldspace jumps all over the galaxy in search of large concentrations of carbon based life. If one is discovered, it is noded and an invasion fleet is sure to follow, assimilating all compatible life under the thrall of the Scourge. Seemingly unable to produce hosts fast enough for their purposes, this cycle looks destined to continue and eventually choke the galaxy in nothing but expired Scourge hosts.



While this (and especially the cloaking devices) makes the Scourge discovery of mankind's domains more feasible, alone it fails to explain how the aliens were able to discover each and every Cradle World before launching the invasion. The chance of finding a single human system purely by chance is remote. To find eight is stretching probability beyond reasonable limits. Most likely, the Scourge used newly converted human hosts to scout out and node the other systems aboard human ships.

A Scourge host is easily recognisable to those who know what to look for and today such activity would be unlikely to succeed, although back when they were unheard of such tactics might have worked. However it was done, the Scourge appear to be channelling the resources of Earth and the Cradle Worlds to repeat the feat, something that mankind cannot allow to happen.

## NEW HORRORS LURKING

The Scourge are a highly adaptable and nefarious race, always seeking out inventive ways of obliterating those that would oppose them and new forms in which to bestride the battlefield.

Surely the most feared of all newly observed Scourge hosts are the dreaded Destroyers. These biological hulks have the might to carry multiple heavy weapons and to crash through solid walls through strength alone. Such hosts surely please the Scourge lucky enough to inhabit one and it seems these are among the species brought by the invaders and bred specifically for the purpose.

The Scourge have also introduced new war machines since the invasions. Their heavily armoured assault walkers and their accompanying dropship, the Harbinger, seem to have been designed together as an unsubtle hammer with which to break enemy lines and hold ground. Such abilities will now be highly valued by the Scourge, who have suddenly found themselves fighting a defensive war they had not anticipated.

Even larger constructs are becoming more commonplace on the frontlines. The towering Annihilator in particular has become an infamous adversary due to its devastating firepower in concert with its self-deploy capabilities.

As the war continues to evolve, it is inevitable that more horrors will be created to adapt, as must only be expected of nature's most terrifying and accomplished predator.



# THE POST-HUMAN REPUBLIC

Status as of Feb 11th, 2671AD (D+251)

Ever since the UCM High Council chose to ignore the advice not to undertake its Reconquest campaign, the PHR has apparently been involved to some extent on every active and potential theatre of combat. Agents and subsequently armies of the Republic have joined the war with calculating precision, always unexpectedly and usually with decisive results. In some cases, it seems that Republic forces may have been in place for sometime before this highly advanced offshoot of humanity chose to reveal itself to the UCM. Since its unveiling, the PHR has introduced a wide range of devastating war machines to the battlefields of the 27th century, dealing death and obliteration wherever it suits their inscrutable purposes.

With such technology and the advice of the alien AI known only as the White Sphere to guide it, the PHR must have some greater design at work in this conflict. As such, its reasonable to conclude that the PHR expected events to unfold as they have done so far (including the rejection of their advice), which generates more unanswered questions about this most evolved branch of humanity...

## THE ANCESTOR'S DILEMMA

As the UCM's time in the field increases, the frequency of reports on Post Human Republic involvement in the war continues to rise. There have been a large number of confirmed engagements and although colonial forces generally forced the enemy to retreat, it was only after the PHR inflicted disproportionate damage. On other occasions, the PHR actually seemed to be assisting the UCM by intervening at certain pivotal moments.

The Republic has not yet taken any action which can be described as full scale, open warfare against their erstwhile kin, however, in view of the large losses sustained in multiple isolated incidents, the UCM High Council has declared all Republic citizens as potential enemies of the state. Military leaders have also permitted commanders in the field to act as they see fit if PHR forces are encountered, which usually translates to fire at will and fire first. This replaced an earlier directive not to fire unless fired upon, which was rescinded after the Elysium Prime ambush incident.



Ultimately, the UCM still does not have a clear plan on how to deal with the PHR and has grossly inadequate intel to make an informed decision. Most military analysts certainly feel that they cannot afford another powerful enemy and would advise against declaring unrestricted war against such a mysterious foe. It seems certain that the PHR are manipulating events to some unknown end, most likely under the advice or orders of the ever more mysterious White Sphere.

In light of this woeful lack of concrete knowledge, the UCM Naval Theories Department (a classified element of Naval Intelligence) has been tasked with gathering as much intel concerning the Republic as possible. At least one attempt has already been made to discover the PHR homeworld/s, although it failed in this objective. The general drive for more intel is yet to officially bear fruit, although Naval Theories is due to deliver a detailed report of its findings to the Council in just a few weeks' time.

Most disturbingly of all, rumours have reached the ears of President Beleque that there is a PHR spy sitting on the High Council itself. If this is indeed true then there is no limit to how far and how extensively PHR operatives may have infiltrated the colonial military and its government. Since all Republic citizens observed have presented a certain 'otherness', easily identified by the sense of the foreign, there is a good chance that the agents are normal human beings, convinced or coerced somehow to cast aside their loyalty. Stringent efforts are currently being made to suppress all rumours of enemy spies however, as an atmosphere of distrust is bound to shake the cohesiveness of the UCM and do great damage to the Reconquest.





## ARMIES GROW, OTHERS TREMBLE

PHR military involvement in the war has been increasing since the very beginning of the Reconquest campaign and has continued to do so to this day. Either these forces are extremely efficient at moving between theatres, or the population and military capacity of the Republic is far larger than first thought. Given their mysterious nature and obvious capacity for manipulation, it could easily be both.

UCM intelligence lists on PHR military technologies grows on an almost weekly basis as some truly formidable fighting units are beginning to make their presence felt. In particular, the enormous and potent Type-4 walkers such as the Hades have generated an atmosphere of fear if ever UCM soldiers are called to face the PHR. The presence of just one of these superior behemoths is enough to swing the odds in smaller engagements, leaving whole battlegroups in tatters within minutes. Most of what the UCM knows of the Hades is derived from shaky battle-cam footage from destroyed vehicles, although on one occasion, a UCM patrol discovered

a single vanquished Hades, surrounded by a mountain of Shaltari corpses and vehicle wrecks.

Type-3 walkers and Jetskimmers have added an unexpectedly fast element to PHR assaults, shattering the myth that PHR forces are incapable of rapid strikes. The Apollo Strike Walker has been a particularly grave threat to rearguard units. Survivors have nervously described the effect of a whole group of near 20ft tall armoured walkers dropping out of the sky on pillars of fire, unleashing kinetic destruction after pulverising the road to dust with the force of their landing. Most of these few survivors are suffering from PTSD and are yet to return to active duty.

Given the rate of military expansion, few UCM generals are under any illusion that the PHR will not continue to introduce fresh technological nightmares to the battlefield and continue to strike in unexpected places. Whatever their ultimate aim, it seems likely that events are proceeding as they envisaged...





# THE SHALTARI TRIBES

Status as of Feb 11th, 2671AD (D+251)

As can only be expected from such an enigmatic and advanced race, the Shaltari's actions in this opening phase of the war have been varied, unpredictable and frequently unfathomable. While they seem to be conducting limited operations in almost every theatre, their significant commitment of forces on the Cradle World of Aaru is obvious. The Shaltari have been fighting both the Scourge and the Resistance there for some time and their warhost is even composed of elements from multiple Tribes - a rarity indeed. This planet seems bereft of any standout qualities that would make it more valuable than any other Cradle World, although records of human-Shaltari conflict stretch back to well before the Scourge invasion on this ancient battlefield.

With the experience of many lifetimes and almost limitless technology, it must be assumed that the Shaltari never do anything without good reason. As such, every seemingly random intervention they have staged so far must be part of a wider scheme. The only argument against this is the tendency of separate Tribes to pursue different policies and often fight against each other; although most analysts believe this to be a testing of strength against the only enemy they have any real respect for - other Shaltari. This deliberate nurturing of disagreement and infighting makes any attempt to understand or predict the Shaltari a fruitless venture and makes them all the more dangerous a factor in the battles to come...

## OUT OF THE BLUE

Most Shaltari attacks on the UCM forces so far in the Reconquest seem to be swift and focused surgical strikes against isolated formations, bringing death and devastation from unknown quarters at any time. If ever an expeditionary force, lead element or supply column disappears without warning or reason, the Shaltari have to be suspected as a matter of routine. For example, it certainly seems likely that small Shaltari armies are disrupting UCM scouting operations around the city of New Athens on Eden Prime by eliminating recon elements with extreme prejudice. Such disruptive activities have combined to slow UCM offensives on multiple battlefronts and will surely result in many more human deaths than the Shaltari suffer in such nefarious activities.

The Shaltari seem to have only committed their forces to full scale engagements in rare circumstances. If estimates about the aliens' low population are accurate it is obvious why they cannot afford such mass slaughter (at least of their own troops). As such, the capricious aliens seem bent on causing as much disruption, chaos and anxiety as possible with the minimum amount of force. Masterly levels of generalship are at work here, as they are clearly achieving this goal with minimal setbacks thus far.



To further complicate things however, there have been several reports of Shaltari forces concentrating their efforts against the Scourge, often to the distinct advantage of the UCM. On one occasion on Elysium Prime, an elite UCMA assault formation had been tasked with the capture of the spaceport of Galileo's Hope. Casualties were projected to be high and battle estimated to last up to three weeks.

When the first boots hit the dropzone, all they found were smouldering Scourge vehicle wrecks and host corpses littered as far as the eyes could see, interspersed with core-collapsed molten slag that were all that was left of Shaltari constructs. This stroke of luck allowed the UCM to capture the spaceport unmolested and gain a foothold in this normally deadly region of the battlefront. Since that time, casualties here have been appalling due to heavy Scourge presence, lending credence to the argument that the Shaltari were certainly not acting to aid the UCM, whatever they were trying to achieve.



## TWO SPIDERS CLASH

The most inadequate of all UCM intelligence dossiers concerns the relationship between the PHR and the Shaltari. Early reports suggested that the PHR were actively working to gain alliances with Tribes notably in conflict with the UCM. This focused prejudice seems to be the result of early paranoia and attempts to easily rationalise the actions both of these poorly understood enemies. The real picture is more confusing however, as PHR and Shaltari diplomats appear to be weaving webs of intrigue and deceit around each other in a dance of dazzling complexity. Experienced UCM ambassadors used to dealing with the conniving aliens now joke that they have finally met their diplomatic match in the 'Humble Aspects of the Post Human Republic'.

Such alliances seem to be as temporary and shifting as sand dunes in a hurricane and instances of conflict between the two sides are increasing exponentially. Perhaps each side is discerning more of the others schemes and liking what they see less and less as the days of war pass by. What seems clear is that neither party has a full understanding of the other, and both are content to resolve their emerging differences on the battlefield as words fail to satisfy.

## MARVELS OF WAR ENTER THE FRAY

As the scope of Shaltari operations in the conflict intensifies, more fabulously advanced and unquestionably lethal war machines have been spotted, wreaking havoc wherever they

appear. Most notable of these new arrivals is the fearsome Firedrake, an aerial predator of sublime killing power. This large construct features several advanced weapons systems capable of long range destruction, becoming increasingly dangerous as it draws closer to the foe. It also incorporates a teleport Gate, allowing it to bring in its own ground support, turning just a single Firedrake into a battlegroup-scale threat all by itself.

The increasing presence of Shaltari Battle Striders in warzones across the Cradle Worlds signal the aliens' intent to pursue longer-term engagements, as these units are focused more on survivability than speed. However, the appearance of the massive Caiman heavy grav-tank illustrates that the lightning assaults and tactical use of speed the Shaltari are famous for are still crucially important elements in their combat doctrine.

Several unorthodox units designed to support the main force through use of Shaltari energy shield technology have also joined the fight, such as the rightfully feared Dreamsnare. In itself, this towering Warstrider is less potent than its Jaguar or Ocelot cousins, although its ability to boost the shields of all surrounding units makes in a primary target in any Shaltari frontal assault formation.

Despite the already infamous impact these new threats have made, it seems likely that the Machiavellian aliens have not opened the doors of their hyper-advanced arsenals all the way. Speculation is rife as to what other technological marvels may stride forth to slay all who oppose the mysterious machinations of the Shaltari...





# THE RESISTANCE

The Resistance is a complex, characterful and disparate assortment of human survivors on the Cradle Worlds and Earth itself, currently occupied by the dreaded alien Scourge. The very existence of the Resistance has shaped UCM military planning for its Reconquest, which became a war of liberation rather than simply a war of revenge as soon as they were discovered. Indeed, the Resistance alone are responsible for a reconquest being possible at all, as they were able to activate and maintain foldspace nodes on all but one of the Crade Worlds, allowing UCM invasion fleets to jump to their locations accurately. Theirs is a tale of loss, grit and determination to survive in the face of insurmountable odds.

We have already seen how the Resistance on Eden Prime evolved from a cowering group of shell-shocked survivors into a viable (if fragmented) fighting force. The example of Eden Prime can be considered as a general model for the progression of Resistance societies across all the Cradle Worlds and Earth itself. However, the most noticeable aspect that separates the Resistance from all other combatants is their diversity.



## YEARS OF ISOLATION

There is no single Resistance society, government plan or mindset. Resistance groups have existed more or less independently of others operating on the same planet and certainly of those offworld. Each society has evolved over 160 years independently, often in very different circumstances, in different terrain and with different fortunes. The Resistance have no fleet and no easy way of communicating beyond their immediate realms. While messages can be conveyed in person, it is extremely risky for them to use long range wireless coms as the Scourge can easily intercept them. There is no fixed size or military structure to any Resistance group either and the true number of living human beings subjugated by the Scourge remains unknown.

Until recently, most Resistance bands have barely deserved their title. Without any real hope of besting an enemy with overwhelming technological and numerical superiority, their existence has been one of survival first, empty gestures second. They have often been at war with each other more frequently than with the Scourge due to squabbles over territory, supplies and sometimes down to the egomania of the most tyrannical of warlords. Raids against the real enemy have usually only occurred when certain materiel has been desperately needed or, on occasion, when they felt they could deal a massive amount of damage disproportionate to their strength.

As UCM scouts and subsequently armies have begun to arrive on the Cradle Worlds the situation is changing rapidly. Resistance societies are at last becoming aware that there is a massive, cohesive human civilisation out there that is actually capable of mounting full scale planetary invasions against their hated oppressors. Many have stepped up their efforts to strike back and are at last committing their most precious assets to the fight for freedom. Most have been all too willing to assist their potential liberators with every ounce of strength they can muster. As with all things concerning the Resistance, this situation is far from consistent...





## 'ALLIES' AND 'FERALS'

Although the terms are grossly inadequate for describing the myriad variations and mindsets of Resistance societies, the UCM has created two broad categories for humans at liberty from the Scourge; Allied and Feral.

Allied societies are defined as those willing or eager to assist the UCM in its efforts for Reconquest. Although still highly divergent, these groups do behave in a vaguely similar way. Most have normally civilised, reasonably sophisticated and often enlightened attitudes to government and the rule of law. These groups vary in size from tiny bands simply glad to see a powerful liberator to large and well governed enclaves which had been hoping for the existence of a society in the stars capable of reversing man's past failings. It is usually these groups that have maintained the foldspace nodes and are natural allies to any that come to their aid after so many years of planning, hoping and waiting.

Some groups, however, are subjugated by the sort of despots normally associated with Ferals, although these are usually shrewd enough to realise what the future will hold once the UCM arrive in force. The UCM's current policy is to work with these kinds of leaders in peace if they cooperate, however distasteful that may be, as their subjects are often visited with more misery than even the Scourge can bring. However, rumours of a secret directive to remove all dictatorial leaders once victory is accomplished are spreading, which makes such individuals even less likely to work with the UCM.

So called 'Ferals' are even more divergent, so much so that sometimes the word is a poor choice to describe them. Nevertheless, the UCM has defined all groups that refuse to cooperate or are actively hostile towards them as Ferals. These societies are usually totalitarian in nature, often controlled by a single, merciless individual. They vary from well organised subterranean dystopian societies where oppression and fear are enforced with ruthless efficiency to literal savages, occasionally driven over the edge of insanity by their plight. The latter are especially feared by UCM ground troops as instances of cannibalism and human sacrifice have been widely reported.

State censors have even been required to step in and silence such talk on occasion - it's devastating for morale when you've been trained to fight Scourge only to be viciously slaughtered by those you're trying to free. Feral warlords often take on grandiose monikers out of all proportion to their power - apparently, the title of King has even been used for the first time in over 300 years of human history. Such individuals are loath to relinquish their lofty positions of power, vice and adoration in exchange for 'liberation'. Even some enlightened societies are opposed to UCM intervention, and see them as just another unwelcome conqueror, almost as foreign to them as the Scourge.

## ENEMIES AND ALLIES

Due to their wide divergence, it's easy to understand how political alliances involving Resistance groups and other races are as complex and varied as their societies. Each individual group approaches things differently, and while some will work actively with the Shaltari, for example, others may have good reason to want to exterminate every

member of that cunning race they encounter. Indeed, Resistance-Shaltari alliances are the most complex and varied of all relations, since both groups are divergent in nature and often unpredictable. It's almost not worth delving into this issue further, as almost every possible political alliance or enmity exists between the Shaltari and Resistance somewhere across the Cradle Worlds.

By contrast, the only interplay that is easily understood and features very few complexities is their feeling towards the Scourge. The vast majority of occupied humans hate their oppressors on principle and without exception. The only real point of difference is how they deal with their respective situations. Some Resistance groups will make every effort to avoid confrontation or contact with any Scourge groups. They feel they have survived by staying silent and unseen and intend to continue with this strategy. Other societies (and those far more likely to appear on battlefields) are currently exploiting the opportunities afforded by the Reconquest to finally revenge themselves on the alien invaders.

The interaction between the Resistance and the PHR is the most concerning and least understood of all their diplomatic relations. Agents of the Republic have been sighted in audiences with several Resistance leaders across multiple Cradle Worlds. Even more worryingly, it seems that the PHR prefer to make contact with the most tyrannical and egotistical warlords they can find. Whether this is because the PHR respect their power, or more likely they feel these individuals are more easily manipulated by their brand of diplomacy, remains to be seen. In any case, it certainly seems that the carefully orchestrated, premeditated betrayal against UCM expeditionary forces in the Asguard system was the work of the Republic. The UCM also has proof that at least one feral leader on Eden Prime, the infamous Salakahn, is in league with the PHR. This may explain why he has been such a thorn in the side of colonial forces from the first day of the invasion, although what either party hopes to gain in the long term remains a mystery.







## TECHNOLOGY OF THE RESISTANCE

Resistance technology is so variable as to be impossible to describe fully. Every Resistance society is unique and certainly no two armies are alike. This is largely a result of over 160 years of isolation from other groups, and of the wildly different fortunes and situations each society had to deal with. Some faced problems unique to them, although almost all had to deal with the reality of occupation by a deadly and unquestionably superior alien foe.

As a result, it's best to discuss the technologies employed by the Resistance in general terms intended to cover the most common themes. The most important distinction to make is that most Resistance armies have a two-tier tech and quality system that is unique to them.

Firstly, their armies usually contain a number of ex-military vehicles and weapons. These are by now usually over 160 years old and sometimes much older than that. As a result, they have needed repairs and modifications over the years making no two vehicles (even of the same pattern) exactly alike. Pre-war technology is not necessarily inferior to UCM machinery, although normally far more expensive and time consuming to produce, designed for very different circumstances and smaller production runs.

These precious and irreplaceable assets have been used sparingly by Resistance commanders who previously committed them to battle only when the situation was dire. Recently, they have started to see more action as the Reconquest gathers pace, with a general sense that the time is nigh to do or die.

Secondly, Resistance armies contain an eclectic mixture of repurposed and modified civilian vehicles, tools and systems. Such ramshackle and second-tier units are normally considered expendable, although their crews usually aren't. Unlike the precious military assets, these scavenged makeweights are far easier to replace than trained crew. They are even more diverse than their military counterparts since there were thousands of pre-war manufacturers, catering for the myriad needs of hundreds of different markets on multiple planets.

As time advances, this picture has blurred further, as military tech gets added to civilian vehicles while civilian tech augments military vehicles. In general terms though, it's easiest to think of the Resistance along these lines. However, if there is one constant among the Resistance, it's that there will always be an exception to every category, rule and term that the UCM attempts to label them with.



### Converted Civilian Vehicles

Resistance forces routinely repurpose abandoned, decadent civilian vehicles to meet their own ends. After the massacres and subsequent assimilations that followed the Scourge invasion, there were literally thousands of these vehicles ready for the taking.

While supplies have dwindled due to Scourge material reclamation patrols, they are still plentiful. Most commonly, these are up-armoured and equipped with various military surplus or homemade weapons. Indeed, 'tricking-out' vehicles has become something of an art form among inventive mechanics. They are easily replaceable assets as such they make up the bulk of most Resistance fighting forces.



### High Crew Capacity

Almost all Resistance vehicles have a higher crew capacity than their UCM counterparts. This is normally due to their pre-war designs or their repurposed nature. Automation is far more common in UCM armies as they are designed for maximum manpower efficiency given their high resource stockpiles with vehicles being more easily replaced than their crews. For the Resistance this is often the other way about, especially with ex-military vehicles. However, it has been argued that extra MK1 eyeballs and human brains as part of a team can still be more effective than one overstressed individual surrounded by automated systems.





## Repurposed Technology

The Resistance often make use of pre-war technology in the function for which it was designed but not perhaps in the application envisaged by its original designers. Civilian units created to perform fairly mundane and

peaceful tasks have often been repurposed to a military role, frequently with surprising effectiveness. Cutting tools, digging machines and other manufacturing hardware were found in abundance in the underground factories of the Cradle Worlds often 'creatively' put to use on the battlefield.



## Legacy Systems

Several Resistance vehicles and aircraft make use of technologies not commonly seen among UCM forces. This is sometimes due to the fact that these systems are entirely obsolete, replaced by something better in every

respect. However, more often than not, the specification and needs of military planners have changed between the pre-war years and the present day to render some technologies more suitable than others. The requirements for UCM high atmosphere orbital drops and efficient, lightweight construction usually make the difference between the technology seen in UCM and Resistance armies.



## Low Atmo Thrusters

A particular example of legacy technology in Resistance armies is the low atmo grade thrusters used on aircraft such as the AT-77 Lifthawk dropship. These are not necessarily

totally inferior to the systems used by the UCM, although they have very different performance characteristics. These units have excellent reliability and provide a higher level of thrust, allowing them to lift the much heavier tanks seen in Resistance armies. However, they have a much higher fuel consumption rate, a very low maximum operating ceiling, and are heavier and are far less efficient than their UCM equivalents.



## Custom Built Additions

Many Resistance vehicles feature more than just extra armour and bolted on weapons. Several incorporate whole sections that have been built from scratch to more radically change the capabilities or function of the original

vehicles. Shown is the combat dais on a battle bus although a plethora of examples are known to exist.



## Air Cushion Vehicles

One particular vehicle type almost unique to the Resistance is the air cushion hovercraft. Such technology had been proven and honed over many hundreds of years, leading to vastly improved performance over 20th

century forebears. Most notably, these hovercraft can

perform over-lift; a temporary boost in thrust to lift entirely above the ground to clear large obstacles and steep inclines. Such a boost very quickly burns out the engines and drinks fuel voraciously, so this cannot be maintained for more than a few seconds. Most importantly, this ability makes these machines totally usable in landlocked urban operations.



## Extra Armour

By far the most common modification is the addition of extra or replacement armour plating. In the case of civilian models, this is usually added copiously, crudely and obviously. Aesthetics are not a

consideration and time is rarely invested to do a neat job. While they do not come close to providing military levels of protection, they do make these contraptions somewhat safer for their crews. In the case of military vehicles, plating is more likely to be from repairs to battle damage or corrosion. With spares running low, a slab of roofing steel may be the only fix to get a venerable tank back into the fight.



## Traditional Treads

Most pre-war tracked vehicles use traditional, multi-part metal treads with rubber grips. These are far more expensive to produce than the mono-piece rubber coated wire composite models that were being pioneered at

the time of the invasion. While they offer advantages in weight and durability during battle, they have one major flaw in that they can't be repaired afterwards. Damaged mono-treads simply have to be swapped out in their entirety. Segmented designs only need the damaged portions replaced - a boon to Resistance forces for whom longevity reigns supreme among desirable qualities.



## Base Independence

Many technologies employed by the Resistance permit extended operations without a permanent base or ideal conditions. In particular, this was a crucial requirement for the survival of aircraft in the early days.

Only those with VTOL capability could be operated long term as obvious airfields were quickly overrun, rendering conventional aircraft worthless. Today, the Resistance are highly adept at operating VTOL flyers from swamps, caves, subterranean bases, ruined cities and icy crevasses.



## Gen-1 Technologies

Some Resistance vehicles feature technologies that would later go on to make a big impact on UCM military production. Magnetic acceleration weapons, mono-treads and active countermeasures were all pioneered

by pre-war manufacturers. Although these early versions are usually considered inferior, it's not always in raw performance. Many times (as with countermeasures) the





systems are of similar effectiveness to modern designs; they were just a lot more expensive to produce with much higher complexity. Occasionally, those with markedly inferior performance led to their adoption in more suitable roles, often proving highly effective.

## RESISTANCE WEAPONRY

When analysing Resistance weaponry, it is a fruitless and unending task to talk of specific systems and patterns. Humanity's pre-war arsenals were full of weapons dating back to various decades, manufactured by a wide range of smaller companies and featuring many improvements. This military had matured and developed over many years of relative peace, as opposed to the rapid, rigorous and focused determination of the UCM.

Since the Scourge invasion, this situation has become even harder to classify as weapons have been adapted, modified and even designed and built from scratch by what can best be described as a cottage industry. As such, it's best to discuss Resistance weapons technology in general terms within context, which will provide a better understanding of their capabilities and mindset.



### Secondary Armaments

Many pre-war military vehicles were less mission-oriented than modern equivalents. They were required to do many jobs and were conceived when production rates were much lower and budgets per unit were higher. As a result, many feature secondary armaments and auxiliary systems that UCM designers would consider unfocused and bloated for their highly specific and efficient arsenals. Sometimes however, these secondary systems make all the difference and they certainly increase tactical flexibility, albeit at a cost.



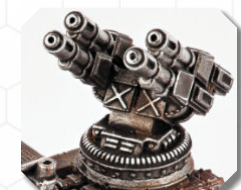
### Coordinated Firepower

Standard Resistance combat doctrine often involves teamwork and coordinated firepower to offset the often inferior qualities of their equipment. Such skills require considerable experience and coolness under fire, qualities that most grizzled Resistance fighters have in abundance. These actions range from focused barrages to overcome countermeasures through sheer weight of fire, to focusing multiple under-powered weapons systems on a single point, greatly increasing their destructive potential.



### Repurposed Weapons

Resistance technicians frequently utilise genuine military weapons in situations their original designers had certainly not envisaged! Helicopter gunship missile pods mounted to trucks, ground AA emplacements welded to the backs of dropships and anti-tank mines carried by bikes have all been documented in use. Such ingenuity has often proved effective when there is a surplus of certain systems with a deficiency in others.



### Servo Mounts

In order to make certain weapons work for unorthodox purposes, some ingenious control systems and adaptations have been required. A good example is the weapon mounts of wagons (truck-sized improvised fighting vehicles). Rather than exposing the gunner to operate a heavy weapon, the operator sits in the cab and controls the weapon through an electronic optical feed, often stripped from consumer video cameras. This meld of technology and practicality is typical of the Resistance.





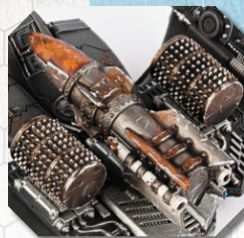
### Conventional Cannons

The most common kinetic energy weapons employed by Resistance tanks are tried and tested conventional cannons. Such chemically fired weapons have been around for many centuries and offer good if unspectacular performance, are extremely simple, dependable and fire basic ammunition. Many Resistance societies even have the capability to manufacture new shells, something far more difficult to do with micro-precision railgun ammunition.



### Grenade Launchers

Grenade launchers are much more common among Resistance armies than they are among the UCM. These weapons pack a considerable punch for their size but are woefully lacking in range. They performed poorly in pitched battles during the Scourge invasion, where even short ranged plasma cannons could fire first. Since UCM armies are designed for massive engagements, their creators focused on range as a key way to combat the Scourge. However, in the close confines of urban combat and in ambush or insurgency ops, these primitive weapons still have their place and are highly valued by Resistance forces.



### Homebrew Weapons

Some Resistance weapons are 100% homemade and were created recently. Usually, these fulfil a role for which pre-war armies had not required or they replace military munitions which have long since been expended. Large flamethrowers and crude but enormous gravity bombs have been seen in use and there is no doubt as to their effectiveness. Very occasionally, Resistance groups are actually in control of functioning factories, so are able to produce brand new units of pre-war technology.



### Captured Weapons

Increasingly, the Resistance has been adapting and using looted Scourge weapons against their hated oppressors. Current understanding of the technology is rudimentary and usually only extends to connecting power or simply picking up and using enemy small arms. In human use these weapons are (sometimes unwittingly) even more devastating than before as a result of over-charging, although such abuse quickly destroys the weapon, necessitating replacement after almost every battle. Poor power regulation can even cause damage to the user, especially with larger weapons such as plasma cannons which have been known to haemorrhage molten plasma, with catastrophic results.

